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2 Peter

2 Peter 1:1

Section 1:1–2: Peter greeted the people to whom he was writing

The letter begins in the usual way that letters began which Christians at that time wrote. First, the person who was writing the letter wrote his name: Simon Peter (verse 1a). Then he wrote the name or description of the people receiving the letter (verse 1b). After that, he included a Christian greeting (verse 2).

1:1a

Simon Peter, a servant and apostle of Jesus Christ,

- ¶ I, Simon Peter, am writing this letter. I serve Jesus Christ. And he has sent me to speak on his behalf.

Simon Peter: It will be clearer to include more information here, like this: “I, Simon Peter, am writing this letter.” Or you could add, “I am writing” in 1:1b. The Greek text and some English versions spell Simon according to the Hebrew spelling: Simeon. But it will be clearer for your readers if you spell Simon in the usual way in your language.

Peter described himself as a “servant” (a literal English translation of the Greek is “slave”) and an “apostle” of Jesus Christ. The word “apostle” means a person that someone sends to speak on his behalf. Peter described himself like this in order to remind the people who read his letter that God had given him the right to teach them. Peter was reminding them of this so that they would consider what he would say to be both true and very important, and so that they would obey him when he told them to do things.

1:1b

To those who through the righteousness of our God and Savior Jesus Christ have received a faith as precious as ours:

- I am writing to you^(plur) who have believed in Jesus Christ in the same way as we^(excl) have believed in him. Jesus Christ who is our God and also our Saviour is the one who has caused us^(incl) all to believe in him. He has done this because he is just.

To those who...: Peter did not write the names of those he was writing to, but it is likely that they were the same group that received his first letter (1 Peter 1:1), because in 3:1 he said that he was now writing to them for the second time. Here Peter simply described the people to whom he was writing as those who trusted in Jesus in the same way that he and the other apostles did.

righteousness: This refers to Christ’s goodness and uprightness. All that he does is right, just and fair. So he enables anyone, not only Jews but people of any race, to believe in him and to become part of his own people.

our God and Savior: These terms probably both refer to Jesus. That is how most versions interpret this phrase.

faith: Most scholars think this refers to the power to believe and trust in Jesus. This is the most likely meaning. But some think that it refers to the teaching that Christians believed, and which Christians had taught to other people who were becoming Christians since the time when the apostles first taught these things (see 3:2b).

as precious as: The Greek word used here can have two meanings:

1. “of equal privilege”. This is the most common meaning of the word. It means that the faith that those reading Peter’s letter have is not inferior to the faith of the apostles. It is the same kind of faith. For example:

for equal standing (RSV, NRSV) (RSV, NRSV)

1. “of equal value”. This is usually translated as BSB: “a faith as precious as ours.” (BSB, NIV, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow the first interpretation (1).

2 Peter 1:2

Section 1:1–2: Peter greeted the people to whom he was writing

The letter begins in the usual way that letters began which Christians at that time wrote. First, the person who was writing the letter wrote his name: Simon Peter (verse 1a). Then he wrote the name or description of the people receiving the letter (verse 1b). After that, he included a Christian greeting (verse 2).

1:2

Grace and peace be multiplied to you through the knowledge of God and of Jesus our Lord.

- May God act very kindly towards you.^(plur) May he also give you very much peace in your hearts, because you know him, and because you also know Jesus our Lord.

Grace and peace: This was a common greeting among Christians at that time (see also 1 Peter 1:2). For “grace” and “peace” see KBT. It may be necessary for

you to translate peace differently according to the context. Here peace means “peace in the heart.”

be multiplied to you: Peter was asking God to continue to give them grace and peace in increasing quantities.

knowledge: This is one of the major themes of the letter. Peter may have been thinking of false teachers who insisted that in order for God to save people, those people needed special secret knowledge. However Peter said that what people really need is to know God and Jesus Christ. See also 1:3, 1:5, 1:6, 1:8, 2:20, and 3:18.

2 Peter 1:3

Section 1:3–15: Peter taught about how people who believe in Christ should behave

Here is the basic message of this section: Christ has given Christians everything they need to live in a way that is good and that pleases him, so every Christian should try hard to become a strong and mature Christian. If they become that kind of Christian, it will be right and proper for God to allow them to enter heaven, Christ’s eternal kingdom.

Paragraph 1:3–4

In the Greek of these 2 verses, it is not clear to whom the 3rd person pronouns, “His,” “Him,” and “He,” refer. It is probable, however, that it is the same person throughout both verses. Both God and Christ are mentioned together in the previous verse, so that does not help us choose. Because of this, many translations (NIV, RSV) leave the pronouns like the Greek, so that the person reading the letter must decide for himself. You may decide to do the same thing. However it may not be possible in your language to do this and therefore you must make a decision. Studying the 2 verses together, it does seem that some of what Peter says about this person, for example, that “he called us,” is normally used only of God himself (see 1 Corinthians 1:9). Therefore, if in your language, you need to make clear to whom these pronouns refer, it would be better to choose God, rather than Christ (see GNT for one way of doing this). The BSB does this by capitalizing the first letter of these pronouns here. This is the interpretation these Notes will follow.

1:3a

His divine power has given us everything we need for life and godliness

- ¶ God has given us^(incl) everything we need to live for ever and to behave in a way which pleases him, by means of the power he has because he is God,

1:3b

through the knowledge of Him

- and by means of our^(incl) knowing him.
- This is possible because we^(incl) know him.

1:3a-b

Peter told the people to whom he wrote this letter that everything they needed to live as genuine Christians was available to them because they now knew God.

His divine power: This refers to the power which God has because he is God.

life and godliness: There are two ways to interpret this:

1. These are two separate ideas, so the meaning is “spiritual (or eternal) life and godly behavior”. (BSB, NIV, JB, NEB, RSV)
2. These are two related words, and one describes the other, so the meaning is “a truly godly life”. (GNT, JBP)

It is recommended that you follow the first interpretation.

godliness: This means the good behavior of a person who has willingly chosen to live for God, and who wants to please him by doing everything in the way God wants him to.

1:3c

who called us by His own glory and excellence.

- It is he who has called us^(incl) to be his people by means of his greatness and his excellent character.

by His own glory and excellence: The Greek words here could mean one of two things:

1. “by means of his own glory and goodness”. This means that God called us to be his people because of his own perfect and glorious character. This is the normal way of understanding the Greek. (BSB, NIV, NEB, JB)
2. “to his own glory and goodness”. This means that God called us to share in his own glory and goodness. (GNT, RSV)

It is recommended that you follow the first interpretation.

glory: See glory in KBT. The word glory means many different things in the New Testament. Here it refers to God’s greatness, his glorious character.

excellence: This also refers to God’s character, to his moral goodness.

2 Peter 1:4

Section 1:3–15: Peter taught about how people who believe in Christ should behave

Here is the basic message of this section: Christ has given Christians everything they need to live in a way that is good and that pleases him, so every Christian should try hard to become a strong and mature Christian. If they become that kind of Christian, it will be right and proper for God to allow them to enter heaven, Christ's eternal kingdom.

Paragraph 1:3–4

In the Greek of these 2 verses, it is not clear to whom the 3rd person pronouns, “His,” “Him,” and “He,” refer. It is probable, however, that it is the same person throughout both verses. Both God and Christ are mentioned together in the previous verse, so that does not help us choose. Because of this, many translations (NIV, RSV) leave the pronouns like the Greek, so that the person reading the letter must decide for himself. You may decide to do the same thing. However it may not be possible in your language to do this and therefore you must make a decision. Studying the 2 verses together, it does seem that some of what Peter says about this person, for example, that “he called us,” is normally used only of God himself (see 1 Corinthians 1:9). Therefore, if in your language, you need to make clear to whom these pronouns refer, it would be better to choose God, rather than Christ (see GNT for one way of doing this). The BSB does this by capitalizing the first letter of these pronouns here. This is the interpretation these Notes will follow.

1:4a

Through these He has given us His precious and magnificent promises,

- It is also by means of God's greatness and excellent character that he has promised that he will do very good and extremely valuable things for us.^(incl)

Through these: The literal meaning of the Greek is “by which.” This may refer to what comes immediately before (God's glory and excellence) or to all of verse 3. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

In this way (GNT)

promises: This word may refer to:

1. promises of things that God will do for us in the future, for example, the promise of a new heaven and earth which Peter wrote about later in the letter (see 3:13). Peter described these promises as “precious” and “magnificent.”

2. the things that God promised to give. This would mean his blessings and gifts (GNT).

If it is necessary in your language to choose between these interpretations, it is recommended that you choose the first interpretation. Try to find words to show that these promises are extremely valuable.

1:4b

so that through them you may become partakers of the divine nature, now that you have escaped the corruption in the world caused by evil desires.

- so that by means of these gifts you may escape from the destructive lust that is in the world and come to share in the divine nature. (GNT)
- He did this so that in this way you^(plur) can be free from wanting to do the bad things which people who do not believe in Christ want to do and which spoil their hearts, and you can become good like God.
- He promised these things, and he will certainly do them, so that you^(plur) can be free from spoiling your hearts like people who do not believe in Christ spoil their hearts by desiring to do evil things. Instead, you can have the same sort of good character as God.

Peter said that when people receive the good things that God has promised to give, God frees them from the evil influence of the world and they become holy like God instead.

The BSB follows the order of the Greek text but it may be more logical in your language to reverse the order of the clauses and follow the order of GNT and the Meaning Lines in the Display.

you: Peter changed from “us” in 1:4a to “you” in 1:4b. But what he was saying obviously applied to himself as well as to those who would read what he had written.

become partakers of the divine nature: This is a difficult phrase to translate. Peter said that a Christian can share in God's own nature. This means that his character can become like God's and he will behave like God does.

escaped: Peter used this word figuratively. Although it literally means “escape,” here it means “be free from.” Peter was saying that the bad way that unbelievers behave would no longer influence the believers to whom he wrote this letter.

corruption: This means literally “the decaying of a dead body.” But the meaning here is probably moral corruption. Peter was saying that when a person desires evil things it spoils that person's heart and character.

the world: Here, and in 2:20, this refers to people who do not believe in Christ.

2 Peter 1:5

Section 1:3–15: Peter taught about how people who believe in Christ should behave

Here is the basic message of this section: Christ has given Christians everything they need to live in a way that is good and that pleases him, so every Christian should try hard to become a strong and mature Christian. If they become that kind of Christian, it will be right and proper for God to allow them to enter heaven, Christ's eternal kingdom.

1:5–7

In these verses Peter wrote about eight traits which should be a part of every Christian's character. If your language has abstract nouns, for example, "faith," you can use these, but in many languages it will be necessary to use verbs to talk about these character traits. The Display of 1:5–7 shows examples of how to use verbs to talk about all these character traits.

1:5a

For this very reason, make every effort to add to your faith virtue;

- ¶ Therefore, now that you^(plur) have believed in Christ, you must also try hard to behave well.
- ¶ Because God has done so much for you^(plur) you should not just/only believe in Christ, you must also try hard to always do what is good.

For this very reason: This probably refers to verses 3 and 4 as a unit and means "because of all that God has done for us."

make every effort: This means "to try very hard." It means that a person should use all his strength to do this.

add to your faith virtue: If you are using abstract nouns, you could express this idea as:

try hard to develop a good character as well as your faith.

1:5b

and to virtue, knowledge;

- As well as behaving well, you^(plur) must also try hard to become people who know how to behave wisely.
- You^(plur) must not only do what is good, you must also become people who know how to behave wisely.

knowledge: This may refer to knowing about things in a way that enables a person to decide wisely about what to do as he lives each day. Or it may refer to

knowing about God and what he wants his people to do.

2 Peter 1:6

Section 1:3–15: Peter taught about how people who believe in Christ should behave

Here is the basic message of this section: Christ has given Christians everything they need to live in a way that is good and that pleases him, so every Christian should try hard to become a strong and mature Christian. If they become that kind of Christian, it will be right and proper for God to allow them to enter heaven, Christ's eternal kingdom.

1:6a

and to knowledge, self-control;

- As well as being people who know how to behave wisely, you^(plur) must also control yourselves so that you do not do the bad things that you want to do.

self-control: This refers to a person controlling his own body, and refusing to do evil things even if he wants to do them.

1:6b

and to self-control, perseverance;

- As well as controlling yourselves, you^(plur) must also be patient in trouble.

perseverance: This refers to being patient while suffering, and to being steadfast. Here is another way to translate this word:

endurance (NRSV)

1:6c

and to perseverance, godliness;

- As well as being patient, you^(plur) must also live in a way which pleases God.

godliness: See note on 1:3a.

2 Peter 1:7

Section 1:3–15: Peter taught about how people who believe in Christ should behave

Here is the basic message of this section: Christ has given Christians everything they need to live in a way that is good and that pleases him, so every Christian should try hard to become a strong and mature Christian. If they become that kind of Christian, it will be right and proper for God to allow them to enter heaven, Christ's eternal kingdom.

1:7a

and to godliness, brotherly kindness;

- As well as living in a way which pleases God, you^(plur) must also treat/love each other as you treat/love the members of your own families.

brotherly kindness: This is one word in Greek. It refers to how brothers and sisters of the same family love each other and show that they care about each other. Christians in Peter's time used it also to refer to how Christians loved other Christians.

1:7b

and to brotherly kindness, love.

- And as well as treating/loving each other like members of your own families, you^(plur) must also love all people.

love: The Greek word Peter used here means "love" for all people, not only for families and other Christians.

2 Peter 1:8

Section 1:3–15: Peter taught about how people who believe in Christ should behave

Here is the basic message of this section: Christ has given Christians everything they need to live in a way that is good and that pleases him, so every Christian should try hard to become a strong and mature Christian. If they become that kind of Christian, it will be right and proper for God to allow them to enter heaven, Christ's eternal kingdom.

1:8a

For if you possess these qualities and continue to grow in them,

- This is how you^(plur) should behave. If you live like this more and more,
- I have told you^(plur) to do these things, because if you do them more and more,

1:8

In this verse Peter told what good results would come if Christians did the things he wrote about in 1:5–7. In the next verse he told about the bad results that would come if they did not do those things.

1:8b

they will keep you from being ineffective and unproductive in your knowledge of our Lord Jesus Christ.

- you^(plur) will know our^(incl) Lord Jesus Christ in a way that causes you to be useful and productive.
- knowing our^(incl) Lord Jesus Christ will not be in vain for you,^(plur) but it will produce good results.

ineffective: This means "useless, unable to do anything good."

unproductive: This is similar in meaning to "ineffective" and means "barren, not producing anything good."

BSB translates these two words in a way that emphasizes their negative meaning. "Ineffective" means "not effective" and unproductive means "not productive." It is also possible to translate the words in a way that expresses a positive meaning. For example:

you will be useful and productive

they will make you active and effective (GNT)

in your knowledge of our Lord Jesus Christ: This may mean one of two things:

1. "concerning your knowing the Lord Jesus Christ." If this is what Peter was saying, he meant that knowing Jesus Christ would result in people living in a good way. For example:

knowing our Lord Jesus Christ has not made your lives either complacent or unproductive. (JBP)

1. "towards knowing the Lord Jesus Christ." If this is what Peter was saying, he meant that if people lived in a good way, it would result in them knowing Jesus Christ even better. For example:

they will bring you to a real knowledge of our Lord Jesus Christ. (JB)

It is recommended that you follow the first interpretation.

2 Peter 1:9

Section 1:3–15: Peter taught about how people who believe in Christ should behave

Here is the basic message of this section: Christ has given Christians everything they need to live in a way that is good and that pleases him, so every Christian should try hard to become a strong and mature Christian. If they become that kind of Christian, it will be right and proper for God to allow them to enter heaven, Christ's eternal kingdom.

1:9a

But whoever lacks these traits is nearsighted to the point of blindness,

- But if a person does not live like this, he is like a person who cannot see well or who is blind.

Here Peter was not talking about problems that people have with their physical eyes. Instead, he was using metaphors to describe spiritual blindness. When people say that a person is spiritually blind, they mean that he does not understand about God or about living God's way. One thing that people should understand about living God's way is that after God has forgiven them for sinning against him, they should live in a way which pleases him. Peter wrote that people who do not understand this are like blind people.

nearsighted to the point of blindness: These are two kinds of eye problems. When a person is nearsighted, he can see clearly only things which are very near to him. When referring to a person's blindness, this indicates that he is completely unable to see. GNT combines the two:

so short-sighted that he cannot see (GNT)

The most important thing to do when you are translating this part of this verse is to check that the people who will read your translation understand that Peter was writing about spiritual blindness.

1:9b

having forgotten that he has been cleansed from his past sins.

- He has forgotten that God has forgiven him for the sins he did before he believed in Christ.

cleansed from his past sins: The Greek verb here, which BSB translates as cleansed, means "to be made clean." The New Testament often talks about a Christian being "cleansed" from his sins (see Titus 2:14). Many scholars believe that Peter is here talking about baptism, but it is probably best to translate this verb as "forgiven" in this context. (For more discussion on this word and other possible ways of translating it, see 1:9 in the UBS Handbook on the Letter from Jude and the Second Letter from Peter.)

2 Peter 1:10

Section 1:3–15: Peter taught about how people who believe in Christ should behave

Here is the basic message of this section: Christ has given Christians everything they need to live in a way that is good and that pleases him, so every Christian should try hard to become a strong and mature Christian. If they become that kind of Christian, it will be right and proper for God to allow them to enter heaven, Christ's eternal kingdom.

1:10a

Therefore, brothers, strive to make your calling and election sure.

- ¶ So, my fellow believers, try even harder to behave well in order to show to yourselves and to other people that God has indeed chosen you and called you to be his people.

Peter told the people to whom he wrote this letter that they should demonstrate by behaving well that God had called them to be his people. When other people saw the Christians behaving well, it would help the other people to understand that God had called the Christians to be his people.

brothers: Peter called the people to whom he wrote this letter his "brothers" because they were also members of God's family. This was a common way for New Testament writers to address those to whom they were writing (see Galatians 1:11; Hebrews 3:12; James 1:2; 1 John 3:13). It may be advisable to translate this as "fellow believers" so that people who read your translation will not think that Peter was writing to his physical brothers.

strive: The Greek contains a word here that the BSB has left implicit. However, this word is in most translations and can have one of two meanings:

1. "more." Most English versions interpret it in this way. They say that here it modifies the meaning of the word strive to mean "strive even more." For example:

be all the more eager (NIV)

try even harder (GNT)

1. "rather." In verse 5, Peter had already urged the Christians to whom he was writing to do all that they could do to live in a good way. So some scholars believe that Peter used the word "rather" in order to contrast what he would write next with the preceding verse. He was saying, therefore, that Christians should not forget that God has cleansed us from the spiritual uncleanness that sinning against him caused. Instead, they should eagerly desire to show others that they were God's people by the way they behave.

It is recommended that you follow the first interpretation (1) like most English versions. See the Meaning Line in the Display for an example.

make your calling and election sure: Here, election means "choice." The Bible clearly states that it is God

who chooses and calls a person to become a Christian (see paragraph 1:3–4). But Peter wrote that Christians must cause their calling by God to be sure and certain. There are two possible ways of understanding this:

1. From the preceding verses, it seems that Peter meant that, by behaving in a way that is full of character traits that are spiritually and morally excellent, we will prove to ourselves and to others that God has called us to be his people.
2. However, some people think that Peter meant that his readers needed to do all these things in order to ensure that their calling and election would not lapse, but would be permanent.

It is recommended that you follow the first interpretation (1) as it fits the context best.

1:10b

For if you practice these things you will never stumble,

- I say this because if you^(plur) do these things, you will at no time turn away from God.

stumble: The Greek word that Peter used here literally means “to stumble” or “to trip.” Here it is used as a figure of speech and can mean one of two things:

1. “to fall away from your faith,” that is, “to turn away from God.” Many versions follow this by saying “fall away” (GNT, JB).
2. “to commit serious sin.” Obviously all Christians sin, but here some scholars believe that Peter was saying that if a believer did all the things he had just been talking about, he would not sin in a really serious way.

The first interpretation (1) is recommended. If you are following this interpretation, try to find an idiomatic expression in your language that means this same thing. Here is an example: “you will at no time leave God’s road.” If you decide to use the word “stumble,” it may be necessary to add something that will tell the people who read your translation that this word refers to turning away from God.

2 Peter 1:11

Section 1:3–15: Peter taught about how people who believe in Christ should behave

Here is the basic message of this section: Christ has given Christians everything they need to live in a way that is good and that pleases him, so every Christian should try hard to become a strong and mature Christian. If they become that kind of Christian, it will be right and proper for God to allow them to enter heaven, Christ’s eternal kingdom.

1:11

and you will receive a lavish reception into the eternal kingdom of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ.

- Then/also God will welcome you^(plur) warmly into the place where Jesus Christ, who is our^(incl) Lord/Master and our Saviour, will rule for ever, so that you can live there for ever.
- Then God will give you^(plur) full permission to enter and live in the place where Jesus Christ, who is our^(incl) Lord and Saviour, will rule as king for ever.

you will receive a lavish reception into the eternal kingdom of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ:

The literal meaning of the Greek is “entrance into the kingdom will be richly provided for you.” The basic meaning of this is obvious: God will gladly allow you to enter heaven which is here described as the eternal kingdom of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ. Modern versions try to express the idea of “lavish” in different ways. For example:

you will be given the full right to enter (GNT)

a rich welcome awaits you (JBP)

you will be afforded full and free admission (NEB)

eternal kingdom: Christ will reign as king forever, and believers will remain forever with him.

2 Peter 1:12

Section 1:3–15: Peter taught about how people who believe in Christ should behave

Here is the basic message of this section: Christ has given Christians everything they need to live in a way that is good and that pleases him, so every Christian should try hard to become a strong and mature Christian. If they become that kind of Christian, it will be right and proper for God to allow them to enter heaven, Christ’s eternal kingdom.

Paragraph 1:12–15

Peter wanted to remind the people who would read this letter of some important truths. He wrote these truths in a letter because he thought that he would soon die. He wanted people to be able to re-read his letters after he had died and to remember what he had taught them.

1:12

Therefore I will always remind you of these things, even though you know them and are established in the truth you now have.

- ¶ So, even though you^(plur) already know these things, and are holding firmly to the true teaching about Christ which people have taught you, I will continue to remind you about them.

the truth you now have: This refers to the Christian message which Christian leaders had taught the believers to whom Peter was writing this letter.

In some languages, a clause that starts with “even though” has to come at the beginning of the sentence. The Display of 1:12 shows one way to do this. Here is another possible way to translate this verse:

I know that you already know these things, and that you are firmly believing the true words that you have learned. But even so, I want to remind you about them again.

2 Peter 1:13

Section 1:3–15: Peter taught about how people who believe in Christ should behave

Here is the basic message of this section: Christ has given Christians everything they need to live in a way that is good and that pleases him, so every Christian should try hard to become a strong and mature Christian. If they become that kind of Christian, it will be right and proper for God to allow them to enter heaven, Christ’s eternal kingdom.

Paragraph 1:12–15

Peter wanted to remind the people who would read this letter of some important truths. He wrote these truths in a letter because he thought that he would soon die. He wanted people to be able to re-read his letters after he had died and to remember what he had taught them.

1:13

I think it is right to refresh your memory as long as I live in the tent of my body,

- I know that while I am still alive, it is right to continue speaking to you^(plur) about them often, so that you will not forget them.

I live in the tent of my body: The Greeks often referred to the body as a “tent,” which is the same as saying that the body is a temporary house for the soul. Here Peter meant simply “while I am still alive.” Unless your language has a similar way of talking about being alive, it will be better if you translate the meaning directly. For example:

as long as I am still alive (GNT)

2 Peter 1:14

Section 1:3–15: Peter taught about how people who believe in Christ should behave

Here is the basic message of this section: Christ has given Christians everything they need to live in a way that is good and that pleases him, so every Christian should try hard to become a strong and mature Christian. If they become that kind of Christian, it will be right and proper for God to allow them to enter heaven, Christ’s eternal kingdom.

Paragraph 1:12–15

Peter wanted to remind the people who would read this letter of some important truths. He wrote these truths in a letter because he thought that he would soon die. He wanted people to be able to re-read his letters after he had died and to remember what he had taught them.

1:14a

because I know that this tent will soon be laid aside,

- For I know that I will soon die,
- For I know that I will not live much longer,

this tent will soon be laid aside: Here Peter described dying as this tent will soon be laid aside. As in verse 13, unless you have a metaphor in your language that speaks of death in a very similar way, it will be better to translate the meaning directly rather than using a metaphor. So you can say, “I will soon die.”

General Comment about 1:13–14: In some languages, it may be necessary to reorder verses 13 and 14. A possible way of translating the reordered verses is:

Our Lord Jesus Christ has made clear to me that I will soon die. Therefore I think that it is right for me to continue to remind you of these things now while I am still alive.

1:14b

as our Lord Jesus Christ has made clear to me.

- because our^(incl) Lord Jesus Christ has clearly told/shown me so.

2 Peter 1:15

Section 1:3–15: Peter taught about how people who believe in Christ should behave

Here is the basic message of this section: Christ has given Christians everything they need to live in a way that is good and that pleases him, so every Christian should try hard to become a strong and mature Christian. If they become that kind of Christian, it will

be right and proper for God to allow them to enter heaven, Christ's eternal kingdom.

Paragraph 1:12–15

Peter wanted to remind the people who would read this letter of some important truths. He wrote these truths in a letter because he thought that he would soon die. He wanted people to be able to re-read his letters after he had died and to remember what he had taught them.

1:15

And I will make every effort to ensure that after my departure, you will be able to recall these things at all times.

- That is why I am working/trying hard to tell you^(plur) these things now, so that you will be able to remember them at all times after I die.

after my departure: Peter spoke of his death as a “departure.” It will be better to translate the meaning directly as “death,” because a literal translation may cause people who read it to think that Peter was physically leaving the place where he was.

2 Peter 1:16

Section 1:16–21: Peter assured those to whom he was writing that what they had learned about Jesus Christ was true

Peter assured the believers who would read his letter that the message which they had heard about Jesus Christ was true. He told them two reasons why they could be sure that this message was true: he himself had seen the majesty of Christ at the time of the Transfiguration, and also the OT prophets had spoken about Christ.

Paragraph 1:16–18

In the Greek text there is the word *gar*, “for,” which connects this paragraph to what precedes it. In this paragraph, Peter explained the first reason why people to whom he wrote could be sure that he wrote the truth. Another way to show how Peter linked this paragraph with what he had said before would be to say:

These things I have been telling you are true.

1:16a

For we did not follow cleverly devised fables when we made known to you the power and coming of our Lord Jesus Christ,

- ¶ When we^(excl) told you^(plur) that our^(incl) Lord Jesus Christ would return with power we^(excl) were not

merely repeating a story/fable which someone else had fabricated in a clever way,

cleverly devised fables: These are tales which are untrue—myths, fables—but which have been devised or invented to sound as if they are true. Peter said that he and the other apostles had not based their message on such tales which people had fabricated. He may have been thinking of the teaching of the false teachers which they based on human ideas (see 2:3a).

the power and coming of our Lord Jesus Christ:

There are two ways to interpret this part of the verse:

1. The two words power and coming both refer to one thing, the return of Christ with great power. GNT translates this part of the verse like this: “the mighty coming of our Lord Jesus Christ.” There are other verses in the NT which speak of Christ returning with great power (see Matthew 24:30).
2. The two words power and coming refer to two separate things. The word power refers to Christ's earthly ministry, during which he performed many miracles, and the word coming refers to his second coming. NEB translates this part of the verse like this: “the power of our Lord Jesus Christ and his coming.” Some commentators think that coming refers to Christ's first coming. They think this because in the following verse, Peter referred to the Transfiguration. But in all the other places where the people who wrote the NT used this Greek word, *parousia* (“arrival, coming”), to refer to Christ, they used it to refer to his second coming and never to his first coming.

The first interpretation is the one recommended.

1:16b

but we were eyewitnesses of His majesty.

- but rather, we^(excl) had seen with our own eyes how great Christ was.

His majesty: This means his splendor, his greatness, how very great he was.

2 Peter 1:17

Section 1:16–21: Peter assured those to whom he was writing that what they had learned about Jesus Christ was true

Peter assured the believers who would read his letter that the message which they had heard about Jesus Christ was true. He told them two reasons why they could be sure that this message was true: he himself had seen the majesty of Christ at the time of the Transfiguration, and also the OT prophets had spoken about Christ.

Paragraph 1:16–18

In the Greek text there is the word *gar*, “for,” which connects this paragraph to what precedes it. In this paragraph, Peter explained the first reason why people to whom he wrote could be sure that he wrote the truth. Another way to show how Peter linked this paragraph with what he had said before would be to say:

These things I have been telling you are true.

1:17a**For He received honor and glory from God the Father**

- We^(excl) know it is true because when God the Father honored him and showed how great he was, we were there.

For: Peter again used this word to link what he would say next with what he had said before. The Display of 1:17a shows one way to translate what Peter meant here.

honor and glory: These two words, honor and glory, are very similar in meaning. Some commentaries say two separate things are referred to: that “honor” refers to what God said and that “glory” refers to how Jesus shone brightly at the time that Peter was talking about. However other scholars think that they are a pair of words that Peter used together in this sentence in order to emphasize in a special way how much God honored Jesus. If that is how Peter used these words, it is possible to translate them together. For example:

greatly honored

truly honored (CEV)

God the Father: This is what the Greek text and most English versions say. If in your language, you need to make clear who God is the father of, you should translate this:

God his Father (LB)

1:17b**when the voice came to Him from the Majestic Glory, saying,**

- This happened when we^(excl) heard God, who is greater than all, saying,

the Majestic Glory: Most commentaries say that this is a way of referring to God without mentioning his name. If you accept this interpretation, you should

translate carefully in a way that ensures that both the voice and the Majestic Glory clearly refer to God the Father. One way to do this is to say “God who is very glorious” or “God who has great glory.”

However, other people think that the Majestic Glory referred to the bright cloud that the men who wrote the Gospel accounts spoke about (see Matthew 17:5).

1:17c**“This is My beloved Son, in whom I am well pleased.”**

- “This person is my son whom I love. I am very pleased with him.”
- “This is my son. I love him. He pleases me completely.”

This is My beloved Son, in whom I am well pleased:

Peter quotes here the words that God the Father (speaking as a voice from heaven) spoke to Jesus, his Son, as recorded in the gospels. Check your translation of these words in Matthew 3:17 and 17:5 (similar in Mark 9:7 and Luke 3:22.) You should translate them the same way here.

This is My beloved Son: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as This is My beloved Son is literally “This is my son the beloved.” The words “the beloved” indicate here that Jesus was God the Father’s one and only dear son. This phrase does not imply that God has other sons whom he did not love.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

This is my own dear Son (GNT)

This is my dearly loved Son (JBP)

This person is my son. I love him.

My beloved Son: The phrase My...Son describes the relationship that Jesus had with God the Father. “God’s Son” or “the Son of God” is a title that was often used to refer to a savior who would be a descendant of King David. God would send this savior to rescue his people. This person was often referred to as the “Messiah” or “Christ.”

The title “the Son of God” also indicates that Jesus has the same nature and character as God. The relationship between God the Father and Jesus, his Son, is similar in some way to the relationship between human fathers and sons. God the Father does not have a physical body. He did not have a sexual relationship with Mary that resulted in her becoming pregnant and

giving birth to Jesus. The Son of God existed eternally as the Son with his Father.

In areas where people do not understand the title “the Son of God” in this way, you may want to include a footnote that explains the correct meaning. Here is a suggested footnote:

This title refers to Jesus. It indicates that Jesus has the same nature and character as God. It does not mean that God the Father had a sexual relationship with Mary that resulted in her becoming pregnant and giving birth to Jesus. Mary became pregnant with Jesus in a miraculous way by the Holy Spirit of God.

In some languages, it is natural to speak of a son as a “child,” without specifying male or female. If that is true in your language, you may use a more general term, such as:

my ChildA translation of the title “the Son of God” must include a familial term such as “son” or “child.” Translations such as “the man who is God,” “the divine man,” or “the God man” are not acceptable, since they do not retain familial language. Examples of acceptable translation options include “the Son who comes from God,” and “the divine/unique/eternal Son of God.”

Other verses will usually make clear that Jesus was a male child. If you use a phrase such as “my male child,” be sure that it does not imply that God had another child who was female.

in whom I am well pleased: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as I am well pleased means “I am delighted” or “I am very pleased/satisfied.”

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

He makes me very happy/pleased.

in him I take great delight (NET)

he makes my heart glad

2 Peter 1:18

Section 1:16–21: Peter assured those to whom he was writing that what they had learned about Jesus Christ was true

Peter assured the believers who would read his letter that the message which they had heard about Jesus

Christ was true. He told them two reasons why they could be sure that this message was true: he himself had seen the majesty of Christ at the time of the Transfiguration, and also the OT prophets had spoken about Christ.

Paragraph 1:16–18

In the Greek text there is the word *gar*, “for,” which connects this paragraph to what precedes it. In this paragraph, Peter explained the first reason why people to whom he wrote could be sure that he wrote the truth. Another way to show how Peter linked this paragraph with what he had said before would be to say:

These things I have been telling you are true.

1:18

And we ourselves heard this voice from heaven when we were with Him on the holy mountain.

- We^(excl) ourselves were indeed with Christ on God’s mountain, and when God spoke from heaven we heard him/his voice/what he said.

Peter emphasized that “we ourselves” heard this voice, so you should emphasize “we” in your translation also. If your language has a special pronoun that people use to emphasize “we,” you should use that pronoun here.

holy mountain: The mountain was holy because of what happened there. For “holy” see KBT. If the only word available in your language means “pure, clean,” then it is better to say “God’s mountain.”

2 Peter 1:19

Section 1:16–21: Peter assured those to whom he was writing that what they had learned about Jesus Christ was true

Peter assured the believers who would read his letter that the message which they had heard about Jesus Christ was true. He told them two reasons why they could be sure that this message was true: he himself had seen the majesty of Christ at the time of the Transfiguration, and also the OT prophets had spoken about Christ.

Paragraph 1:19–21

The Transfiguration proved that the message about Jesus was true, but that is not all that proved it. The writings of the prophets also confirmed that this was a true message.

1:19a

We also have the word of the prophets as confirmed beyond doubt.

- ¶ We^(incl) also know that the words which the prophets wrote concerning Christ are very true, and they agree with our^(excl) teaching about his return.
- We^(incl) also know that we can with certainty depend/rely on the words which the prophets wrote concerning Christ and they confirm what we^(excl) taught you^(plur) about his return.

We: This may refer to all believers. If it does, the pronoun is inclusive. Or it may refer to all the apostles, or just to the three apostles who had seen the Transfiguration. If the pronoun refers only to the apostles, it is exclusive. It seems more likely that the first interpretation is the correct one, because the words of the prophets in the OT are for all believers.

confirmed beyond doubt: The form of this word in the Greek text here can mean “very, very certain.” This meaning fits the context well. However some commentators think that here Peter was making a comparison and saying that people can now be even more confident that the words of the prophets are true than they could be before the Transfiguration because the apostles saw Moses and Elijah talking with Jesus at the Transfiguration. Here are some other ways that translate this:

so we have confirmation of what was said in prophecy (JB)

all this confirms for us the message of prophecy (NEB)

Peter referred to the words of the prophets to support what he taught about Christ’s return. In order to clearly communicate this, it may be necessary for you to include this implied information, as in the Display of 1:19a.

1:19b

And you will do well to pay attention to it, as to a lamp shining in a dark place,

- You^(plur) should listen well to those words, because like a lamp shining in the darkness helps people to see the right way to go, these words will help you know what is true.

a lamp shining in a dark place: Peter compared what the prophets wrote to a lamp shining in the darkness. Just as a lamp shining in a dark place shows people the right way to go, so the words that the prophets wrote will show people what is true and what is false.

1:19c

until the day dawns and the morning star rises in your hearts.

- Keep listening to those words until Christ returns and makes things clear to you^(plur) which will be like the daylight coming and the morning star shining in your hearts.

the day dawns and the morning star rises in your hearts:

The type of lamp that Peter mentioned in 1:19b radiated light so that people could see until the morning star appeared and daylight returned. The morning star is the bright star (actually a planet, the planet Venus) which rises immediately before dawn. Does this star have a special name in your language? There are a number of examples in Scripture where the writers used similar metaphors in a way that shows that the morning star very probably refers to Christ. See Revelation 22:16 and Luke 1:78. In the same way that the morning star brings light to a dark world, the coming of Christ brings light into the hearts of believers and enables them to know God more fully. Peter was almost certainly thinking of Christ’s second coming, since “the day” in the NT usually referred to this, as in Romans 13:12.

General Comment about 1:19b–c: Here is one example of how you could translate 1:19b and 1:19c in order to clearly express all of the meaning of the metaphors:

You should listen well to those words until our Lord Jesus Christ returns. His coming will bring light like the dawn of a new day, and he will be like the morning star. At that time his light will shine in your hearts and reveal God to you clearly.

2 Peter 1:20

Section 1:16–21: Peter assured those to whom he was writing that what they had learned about Jesus Christ was true

Peter assured the believers who would read his letter that the message which they had heard about Jesus Christ was true. He told them two reasons why they could be sure that this message was true: he himself had seen the majesty of Christ at the time of the Transfiguration, and also the OT prophets had spoken about Christ.

Paragraph 1:19–21

The Transfiguration proved that the message about Jesus was true, but that is not all that proved it. The writings of the prophets also confirmed that this was a true message.

1:20

Above all, you must understand that no prophecy of Scripture comes from one’s own interpretation.

- It is really important that you^(plur) understand that none of the prophets when they wrote in God's Book wrote just their own ideas.
- It is really important that you^(plur) understand that the words of the prophets which you read in Scripture are not just the prophet's own ideas.

In this verse and the next Peter emphasized that people can rely on prophecy because the prophets did not speak by their own wisdom, but rather spoke what the Spirit of God inspired them to speak.

Above all: The literal meaning of the Greek is "first." Peter wanted to emphasize that what he would say next would be very important.

no prophecy...comes from one's own interpretation: The Greek here is more literally "No prophecy... is a matter of one's own interpretation" (see RSV). It is unclear whose "interpretation" Peter is referring to. There are two main ways to understand this part of the verse:

1. Some scholars believe it refers to the prophet's own interpretation, that is, none of the OT prophets spoke any prophecy by his own power. This meaning fits with verse 21 which says it was God's Spirit who inspired them.
2. Other scholars believe it refers generally to any person who hears or reads an OT prophecy. No one who hears or reads an OT prophecy should explain/interpret it by his own power. Peter was saying that no person had the right to interpret Scripture according to that person's own ideas. If this interpretation is the correct one, then in this verse Peter was referring ahead to chapter 2 where he would speak about false teachers who twisted the meaning of Scripture as they wished. For example:

the interpretation of scriptural prophecy is never a matter for the individual (JB)

No one can interpret any prophecy of Scripture himself (NEB)

It is recommended that you follow the first interpretation (1). If, however, you decide to accept the second interpretation, you could translate it like this:

You must understand that when a person reads the words of the prophets in Scripture and explains the meaning of those words according to his own thinking, he is not acting rightly.

This verse is very important for doctrine, so if you have footnotes in your translation, you should include a note that explains the interpretation which you have not followed in the main text.

2 Peter 1:21

Section 1:16–21: Peter assured those to whom he was writing that what they had learned about Jesus Christ was true

Peter assured the believers who would read his letter that the message which they had heard about Jesus Christ was true. He told them two reasons why they could be sure that this message was true: he himself had seen the majesty of Christ at the time of the Transfiguration, and also the OT prophets had spoken about Christ.

Paragraph 1:19–21

The Transfiguration proved that the message about Jesus was true, but that is not all that proved it. The writings of the prophets also confirmed that this was a true message.

1:21a

For no such prophecy was ever brought forth by the will of man,

- I say this because the prophets did not ever write/speak anything merely because they themselves or some other person wanted them to write/speak.

no such prophecy was ever brought forth by the will of man: No prophecy originated from what the prophet himself wanted to say or from what other people wanted him to say.

1:21b

but men spoke from God as they were carried along by the Holy Spirit.

- Instead, the Holy Spirit took control of them/their thoughts and caused them to write/speak words from God.
- Instead, the Holy Spirit took control of them/their thoughts and caused them to write/speak the words God wanted them to write/speak.

but men spoke from God as they were carried along by the Holy Spirit: Instead of merely saying what they wanted to say, the OT prophets said what the Spirit of God moved or drove them to say. Luke used the same word in Acts 27:15 and Acts 27:17 to describe a ship that the wind was driving in a way that the people on the ship could not control. The prophets spoke and wrote "under the control of the Holy Spirit" (GNT).

2 Peter 2:1

Section 2:1-22: Peter warned believers against false teachers

In this section, Peter warned the people who read his letter against false teachers who behaved wickedly and who would try to encourage believers to behave in the same immoral way as they did. But God would certainly destroy these false teachers.

Many of the verses in this section are similar to verses in Jude's letter. Whoever wrote second, Peter or Jude, may have had a copy of the other one's letter and used words and ideas out of that letter. Or perhaps someone else had written something with similar words and ideas in it, and Peter and Jude both used words and ideas from that writing. Why these two letters are so similar is not the most important thing. But if you have already translated Jude, it is important to have that translation open in front of you while you are studying and translating this section of 2 Peter. However be careful not to copy any verse exactly from Jude's letter to your translation of 2 Peter, because there are differences between them which must remain in your translation.

Paragraph 2:1-3

Peter warned that false teachers would come and deceive many people, but he also said that God would punish these false teachers in the end.

2:1

In the history of the Jewish people there had been many false prophets. Peter warned that, in the same way, false teachers would come among the Christians.

2:1a

Now there were also false prophets among the people,

- ¶ Long ago there were also prophets among God's people who spoke lies in the name of God.
- ¶ Long ago, as well as true prophets there were also people among God's people who said that they were speaking messages from God but were really lying.

Now: At the end of chapter 1 Peter had been talking about true prophets. He used the word Now here to contrast these true prophets with the false prophets who had come among God's people in the past. GNT and CEV do not retain this link. Another way to show the link would be as follows:

But, in the past, even though there were true prophets, there were also men among God's people who said that they were prophets, but they taught lies, not the truth.

false prophets: These are people who say that their messages come directly from God, but they are lying.

the people: Jews used the phrase "the people" to refer to themselves, God's chosen people, the Jewish people. Here, Peter was referring to the Jewish people, the people of Israel, in the time of the OT.

2:1b

just as there will be false teachers among you.

- In the same way, among you^(plur) there will be people who become teachers who teach lies.
- In the same way, as well as those who teach you^(plur) true things about God there will be people among you who teach you lies instead.

2:1c

They will secretly introduce destructive heresies,

- They will teach lies about God, but they will not allow anyone to know that they are lies. These lies will ruin the people who believe them.
- They will teach lies while pretending to teach the truth. These lies will ruin the hearts of those people who believe them.

2:1b-c

false teachers This refers to those who were teaching the "destructive heresies".

secretly introduce: These words translate a single Greek verb that means "bring in," and which sometimes means even more: "bring in secretly so that other people will not notice what is happening." Many scholars believe that it has this extra meaning here. So BSB translates it secretly introduce, see also JB: "insinuate" and RSV "secretly bring in." But GNT and NEB do not include this extra meaning.

destructive heresies: Heresy is a doctrine or teaching about God which is untrue. Such teachings lead people to live wickedly. When people live wickedly, God judges them. This is how heresies destroy them.

2:1d

even denying the Master who bought them—

- These teachers will even disown Christ their Master who set them free from sin.

denying the Master: The Greek word here that BSB translates denying means "to deny, disown someone." Here it probably means that although these people said that they followed Christ, they showed by what they did and by what they taught other people, that they did not really follow his teachings. It could also mean that they were "denying" Christ by saying untrue things about him like "he didn't die for our sins."

Master: This translates the Greek word that usually in the NT refers to God, but here clearly Peter was using it about Christ. This is the word that people used to refer to a person who owned slaves. This word fits well here because of the next words which speak about Christ buying people.

who bought them: When Peter said Jesus “bought” people, he is using a metaphor. When Jesus died on the cross, the blood he shed was like the money someone gives the owner of a slave so that the slave can be free from his old master and can have a new master.

2:1e bringing swift destruction on themselves.

- Because they do that, they will cause God to destroy them soon.
- They will cause their own ruin to come soon.

bringing swift destruction on themselves: Peter said that the way the false teachers were behaving would cause God to destroy them.

swift: The Greek word which BSB translates swift can mean “sudden” or “imminent, soon.” It is the same word that Peter used in 1:14 when he said that he would die soon, and that is probably the meaning here. He is not saying that God would suddenly destroy the false teachers, but that he would do it soon.

destruction: The Greek word *apōleia*, “destruction,” is the same word as BSB translated “destructive” in 2:1c. It means “destruction, loss, ruin.” Here Peter was probably not referring to physical destruction, but spiritual ruin, or he may have meant that their influence over people would be destroyed. See destroy in KBT.

2 Peter 2:2

Section 2:1–22: Peter warned believers against false teachers

In this section, Peter warned the people who read his letter against false teachers who behaved wickedly and who would try to encourage believers to behave in the same immoral way as they did. But God would certainly destroy these false teachers.

Many of the verses in this section are similar to verses in Jude’s letter. Whoever wrote second, Peter or Jude, may have had a copy of the other one’s letter and used words and ideas out of that letter. Or perhaps someone else had written something with similar words and ideas in it, and Peter and Jude both used words and ideas from that writing. Why these two letters are so similar is not the most important

thing. But if you have already translated Jude, it is important to have that translation open in front of you while you are studying and translating this section of 2 Peter. However be careful not to copy any verse exactly from Jude’s letter to your translation of 2 Peter, because there are differences between them which must remain in your translation.

Paragraph 2:1–3

Peter warned that false teachers would come and deceive many people, but he also said that God would punish these false teachers in the end.

2:2a

Many will follow in their depravity,

- Many who say they are believers will imitate the immoral way that they behave,

Many: This means many of the people who claimed to be Christians.

depravity: The Greek word means “very bad, immoral behavior.” It often refers specifically to sexual immorality, but not always. The other places that Peter used this word in his letters are 1 Peter 4:3, and 2 Peter 2:7, 2:18.

2:2b

and because of them the way of truth will be defamed.

- and other people who are not believers will say bad things about the true way of living because of the way they behave.
- and as a result, other people who are not believers will say bad things about the true way to live.

the way of truth: This means the true way to live, the way Jesus and the true teachers had taught Christians to live.

will be defamed: The literal meaning of the Greek is “blaspheme, say bad things about.” Peter was saying that the bad behavior of the people who claimed to be Christians but who followed the false teachers would cause other people to say bad things about the Christian teaching about how to live.

2 Peter 2:3

Section 2:1–22: Peter warned believers against false teachers

In this section, Peter warned the people who read his letter against false teachers who behaved wickedly and who would try to encourage believers to behave in the same immoral way as they did. But God would certainly destroy these false teachers.

Many of the verses in this section are similar to verses in Jude's letter. Whoever wrote second, Peter or Jude, may have had a copy of the other one's letter and used words and ideas out of that letter. Or perhaps someone else had written something with similar words and ideas in it, and Peter and Jude both used words and ideas from that writing. Why these two letters are so similar is not the most important thing. But if you have already translated Jude, it is important to have that translation open in front of you while you are studying and translating this section of 2 Peter. However be careful not to copy any verse exactly from Jude's letter to your translation of 2 Peter, because there are differences between them which must remain in your translation.

Paragraph 2:1-3

Peter warned that false teachers would come and deceive many people, but he also said that God would punish these false teachers in the end.

2:3

Peter wrote that the false teachers would be greedy people who would lie in order to deceive other people. He wrote that this is how they would try to convince people to give them money, but that God would judge and destroy these false teachers.

2:3a

In their greed, these false teachers will exploit you with deceptive words.

- These teachers will be greedy, and they will deceive you^(plur) by telling you stories which they have fabricated in order to get things/money from you.

exploit: This means "profit dishonestly from someone, cheat someone."

deceptive words: The literal meaning of the Greek is "forged/fabricated words." This refers to the teaching of the false teachers. It is similar to the words which Peter used in 1:16a. There he said that what he and the other apostles taught were not fabricated stories. Now here in 2:3, Peter was saying that the false teachers would be the ones who would use stories that someone had fabricated.

2:3b

The longstanding verdict against them remains in force,

- God decided long ago that he would punish them and he is ready to do it.

For a long time, even before Peter wrote these words, God had been ready to judge, condemn and destroy the false teachers.

The longstanding verdict against them remains in force: The literal meaning of the Greek is "for whom condemnation is not idle." The Greek word that BSB translates as verdict means "judgement, decision." It can refer to the decision a judge takes in court when he says that a person has done something wrong and deserves to be punished. Sometimes the word refers to the punishment itself. That is what it refers to here.

2:3c

and their destruction does not sleep.

- He will certainly destroy them.

their destruction does not sleep: This use of the negative not is really a vivid way of saying the opposite: "destruction is on the way" (NLT). This is similar in form and meaning to 2:3b. Peter spoke about destruction as if it were a person doing something. If you are unable to do this in your language, you will need to state the meaning in a different form as you did in 2:3b. God is the one who will destroy the false teachers, just as he was the one who would condemn and punish them in 2:3b.

destruction: See note on 2:1e.

2 Peter 2:4

Section 2:1-22: Peter warned believers against false teachers

In this section, Peter warned the people who read his letter against false teachers who behaved wickedly and who would try to encourage believers to behave in the same immoral way as they did. But God would certainly destroy these false teachers.

Many of the verses in this section are similar to verses in Jude's letter. Whoever wrote second, Peter or Jude, may have had a copy of the other one's letter and used words and ideas out of that letter. Or perhaps someone else had written something with similar words and ideas in it, and Peter and Jude both used words and ideas from that writing. Why these two letters are so similar is not the most important thing. But if you have already translated Jude, it is important to have that translation open in front of you while you are studying and translating this section of 2 Peter. However be careful not to copy any verse exactly from Jude's letter to your translation of 2 Peter, because there are differences between them which must remain in your translation.

Paragraph 2:4-10a

Peter wrote this paragraph mainly to support what he said in 2:3b-c. He supported what he had said by telling three examples from the OT of how God punished wicked people and rescued people who obeyed

him. These were examples with which the people to whom he wrote this letter would have been familiar.

In the Greek this whole paragraph is one long sentence, but it may be necessary for you to break it up. Read GNT and notice how that version has broken the one sentence into several shorter sentences. Perhaps you should begin this paragraph with “See” or “You know that.” Think about whether that would help people who read your translation to understand that Peter was starting to prove a point here. You may even need to repeat the “See” or “You know that” each time Peter used a new example.

Although verses 4, 5, 6, 7 and 9 begin with “if” in the BSB, this is not because the events which Peter was talking about may not have happened. These events all did happen. This use of “if” in English (and Greek) was to prove a point, here what Peter said in verse 9. The GNT shows one way to communicate this meaning without using the word “if” at all.

2:4

For: Peter was now going to say why God would certainly punish the false teachers. GNT and CEV consider the link between the previous paragraph and the one that starts here in 2:4 to be clear enough, so they do not include any explicit translation of “For.” If it is necessary to clearly state the link in your language, you could say something like:

I say that God is going to punish them because...

2:4a

For if God did not spare the angels when they sinned,

- ¶ You^(plur) know that long ago when some angels sinned, God did not ignore the evil that they had done.
- ¶ Remember that long ago when some of the angels disobeyed God, he did not fail to punish them for what they did.

God did not spare the angels: This means that he did not overlook their sin. Instead, he punished them.

angels: The first example from the OT that Peter wrote about is what happened to the wicked angels. Scholars do not know for certain which angels were being referred to. Bible scholars are not certain who these angels were. Some think the angels are “the sons of God” that Genesis 6:1–4 mentions, who came down to earth and married human women. But other scholars strongly disagree. They say that the phrase “sons of God” in Genesis does not refer to angels at all but rather to the descendants of Adam’s son, Seth. (One of

the reasons they say that Genesis 6 does not refer to angels is because Jesus said in Mark 12:25 that angels do not marry.)

2:4b

but cast them deep into hell,

- He imprisoned them in the deep hole where he imprisons all wicked people.

hell: The Jews and Greeks who lived at the time when Peter was writing his letter believed that there was a deep pit under the earth where God imprisoned wicked angels and humans in order to punish them.

2:4c

placing them in chains of darkness to be held for judgment;

- He will keep them in that dark prison until the day when he will judge and punish them.
- They will stay there in the darkness until the day when he will judge them.

chains of darkness: There is a problem in the Greek text here. Some manuscripts have “chains (seirais) of gloom” while others have “pits (sirois) of gloom.” That is why BSB says “chains of darkness” while some translations say “gloomy dungeons.” But the meaning of the two possible Greek phrases is almost the same. They both mean that God has imprisoned the wicked angels.

darkness: This means “nearly dark.” The word describes what a place looks like when there is almost no light there.

2 Peter 2:5

Section 2:1–22: Peter warned believers against false teachers

In this section, Peter warned the people who read his letter against false teachers who behaved wickedly and who would try to encourage believers to behave in the same immoral way as they did. But God would certainly destroy these false teachers.

Many of the verses in this section are similar to verses in Jude’s letter. Whoever wrote second, Peter or Jude, may have had a copy of the other one’s letter and used words and ideas out of that letter. Or perhaps someone else had written something with similar words and ideas in it, and Peter and Jude both used words and ideas from that writing. Why these two letters are so similar is not the most important thing. But if you have already translated Jude, it is important to have that translation open in front of you while you are studying and translating this section of 2 Peter. However be careful not to copy any verse

exactly from Jude's letter to your translation of 2 Peter, because there are differences between them which must remain in your translation.

Paragraph 2:4-10a

Peter wrote this paragraph mainly to support what he said in 2:3b-c. He supported what he had said by telling three examples from the OT of how God punished wicked people and rescued people who obeyed him. These were examples with which the people to whom he wrote this letter would have been familiar.

In the Greek this whole paragraph is one long sentence, but it may be necessary for you to break it up. Read GNT and notice how that version has broken the one sentence into several shorter sentences. Perhaps you should begin this paragraph with "See" or "You know that." Think about whether that would help people who read your translation to understand that Peter was starting to prove a point here. You may even need to repeat the "See" or "You know that" each time Peter used a new example.

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2:5a

if He did not spare the ancient world when He brought the flood on its ungodly people,

- You^(plur) also know that when the people who lived long ago did not fear God, he did not ignore the evil things that they were doing. Instead he punished them by drowning them in a flood.
- You^(plur) also know that when the people who lived long ago at the same time as Noah disregarded God, he did not fail to punish them for the bad things they were doing. He caused water to cover the earth so that they drowned.

The second example that Peter mentioned here are the wicked people of Noah's time. God punished them by causing a flood to cover the earth and drown them, but he saved Noah who was a good man. You can read about this in Genesis 6-9.

the ancient world: This refers to the world long ago at the time of Noah.

its ungodly people: This means people who do not fear/respect God and therefore behave in a wicked way because they do not obey him. See also 2:6b and 3:7b.

2:5b

but preserved Noah, a preacher of righteousness,

- But he saved Noah who was telling people at that time that they should do only what God said was right.
- But at that time Noah was telling the people that they should not do those bad things but live in the way God considered good. Therefore God saved him and he did not drown.

preacher of righteousness: Here Peter probably meant that Noah was telling the people they should live in a way that God considered good. However some scholars think it means that Noah himself was righteous, a good man. Or Peter may have meant to include both these ideas.

2:5c

among the eight;

- Yes, God saved him and seven other people.

the eight: These were the members of Noah's family; his wife, his three sons and their wives (see Genesis 8:18).

2 Peter 2:6

Section 2:1-22: Peter warned believers against false teachers

In this section, Peter warned the people who read his letter against false teachers who behaved wickedly and who would try to encourage believers to behave in the same immoral way as they did. But God would certainly destroy these false teachers.

Many of the verses in this section are similar to verses in Jude's letter. Whoever wrote second, Peter or Jude, may have had a copy of the other one's letter and used words and ideas out of that letter. Or perhaps someone else had written something with similar words and ideas in it, and Peter and Jude both used words and ideas from that writing. Why these two letters are so similar is not the most important thing. But if you have already translated Jude, it is important to have that translation open in front of you while you are studying and translating this section of 2 Peter. However be careful not to copy any verse exactly from Jude's letter to your translation of 2 Peter, because there are differences between them which must remain in your translation.

Paragraph 2:4-10a

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him. These were examples with which the people to whom he wrote this letter would have been familiar.

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2:6

The third example Peter gave in this chapter is of the wicked people of the cities of Sodom and Gomorrah. God sent down fire upon these cities and destroyed them so completely that nothing was left of them but ashes. This also shows that God will punish ungodly, wicked people. You can read about this in Genesis 19:1–29.

2:6a

if He condemned the cities of Sodom and Gomorrah to destruction, reducing them to ashes

- You^(plur) also know that long ago God condemned the people who lived in the cities of Sodom and Gomorrah because they had done wicked things and he burned them and their cities completely until only ash remained.
- You^(plur) also know that long ago God decided that the people of the cities of Sodom and Gomorrah deserved to be punished because of the wicked things they had done. Therefore he destroyed them and their cities by burning them completely until only ashes were left.

if He condemned...to destruction, reducing them to ashes: God, as a judge, had looked at the evil way the people of Sodom and Gomorrah were behaving and decided that they deserved to be punished.

condemned...to destruction: The version of the Greek Bible that the BSB follows, says condemned...to destruction (instead of just “condemned”). Here are some other translations that follow this text:

he condemned them to extinction (RSV)

condemned them to total destruction (NEB)

Whether you use the translation condemned...to destruction or simply “condemned”, the basic meaning is the same.

the cities of Sodom and Gomorrah: Although Peter said that God condemned the cities of Sodom and Gomorrah, he meant that God condemned the people who were in those cities. It may be necessary for you to make that clear in your translation.

2:6b

as an example of what is coming on the ungodly;

- When he did this, he showed people that he will punish those people who disregard him.
- When he punished them like this, he showed what will happen to people who do not fear him.

the ungodly: See the note on 2:5a.

2 Peter 2:7

Section 2:1–22: Peter warned believers against false teachers

In this section, Peter warned the people who read his letter against false teachers who behaved wickedly and who would try to encourage believers to behave in the same immoral way as they did. But God would certainly destroy these false teachers.

Many of the verses in this section are similar to verses in Jude’s letter. Whoever wrote second, Peter or Jude, may have had a copy of the other one’s letter and used words and ideas out of that letter. Or perhaps someone else had written something with similar words and ideas in it, and Peter and Jude both used words and ideas from that writing. Why these two letters are so similar is not the most important thing. But if you have already translated Jude, it is important to have that translation open in front of you while you are studying and translating this section of 2 Peter. However be careful not to copy any verse exactly from Jude’s letter to your translation of 2 Peter, because there are differences between them which must remain in your translation.

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Although verses 4, 5, 6, 7 and 9 begin with “if” in the BSB, this is not because the events which Peter was talking about may not have happened. These events all did happen. This use of “if” in English (and Greek) was to prove a point, here what Peter said in verse 9. The GNT shows one way to communicate this meaning without using the word “if” at all.

2:7–8

There was only one man living in Sodom who was not wicked. That was Lot. The wicked way the other people living in Sodom behaved saddened him, and God rescued him from the city before he burned it.

2:7a

and if He rescued Lot, a righteous man

- Before he burned Sodom, he saved Lot, who was a good man.
- But before he destroyed Sodom, he made Lot, who was a good man, leave the city and so he saved him.

2:7b

distressed by the depraved conduct of the lawless

- Lot had been very unhappy/troubled because the people of Sodom did not obey any laws and did shameful/immoral things.

distressed: This is a strong word which means “very upset, troubled.” Try to find a strong idiom in your language.

depraved conduct: This is the same word that BSB translated as “depravity” in verse 2. See the note on 2:2a.

the lawless: This refers to people who ignored the laws (human laws and God’s laws) and behaved as they wanted to.

2 Peter 2:8

Section 2:1–22: Peter warned believers against false teachers

In this section, Peter warned the people who read his letter against false teachers who behaved wickedly and who would try to encourage believers to behave

in the same immoral way as they did. But God would certainly destroy these false teachers.

Many of the verses in this section are similar to verses in Jude’s letter. Whoever wrote second, Peter or Jude, may have had a copy of the other one’s letter and used words and ideas out of that letter. Or perhaps someone else had written something with similar words and ideas in it, and Peter and Jude both used words and ideas from that writing. Why these two letters are so similar is not the most important thing. But if you have already translated Jude, it is important to have that translation open in front of you while you are studying and translating this section of 2 Peter. However be careful not to copy any verse exactly from Jude’s letter to your translation of 2 Peter, because there are differences between them which must remain in your translation.

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2:8

(for that righteous man, living among them day after day, was tormented in his righteous soul by the lawless deeds he saw and heard)—

- He lived among those bad people, and every day he saw the bad things they did and heard the wicked things they said, and all of this upset him very much, because he was a good man.

This verse describes more about how Lot felt about his wicked neighbors. The wicked actions he saw and

heard “tormented” his heart. “Tormented” is even stronger than “distressed” in verse 7.

lawless deeds: Although the Greek word for lawless that Peter used here is different from the one he used in 2:7b, the meaning is the same. (The BSB translates both Greek words as “lawless”. These were the actions of people who did not fear or respect God.

2 Peter 2:9

Section 2:1–22: Peter warned believers against false teachers

In this section, Peter warned the people who read his letter against false teachers who behaved wickedly and who would try to encourage believers to behave in the same immoral way as they did. But God would certainly destroy these false teachers.

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all did happen. This use of “if” in English (and Greek) was to prove a point, here what Peter said in verse 9. The GNT shows one way to communicate this meaning without using the word “if” at all.

2:9

This is what Peter used the examples in 2:4–8 to prove. The three examples show that God will punish wicked people and rescue good people.

2:9a

if all this is so, then the Lord knows how to rescue the godly from trials

- All these things that God has done in the past show us^(incl) that the Lord God will certainly keep safe when they are in trouble people who live the way God wants them to live.
- Because God has acted like this in the past, we^(incl) can be certain that he will continue to rescue people who obey him when they are being tested.

if all this is so: These words are not in the Greek text, but BSB includes them to show that Peter was now stating what all that he had said from verse 4 to 8 proved. The Display line of 2:9a shows a longer way to express this link. Here is a short way to express this link:

therefore

the Lord knows how to: The meaning here is not just that God knows how to rescue godly people, but that he will certainly do it. It could also mean “he is accustomed to do it.”

the Lord: Here the Lord refers to God, not Jesus, and it may be necessary for you to translate it as “Lord God” to make this clear.

the godly: This is the opposite of the word translated “ungodly” in 2:5, 6. Godly people are those who do fear God and, as a result, behave in the way God wants them to. See also the note on “godliness” in 1:3a.

trials: Peter was thinking here about how Christians suffer when they live in a pagan society.

2:9b

and to hold the unrighteous for punishment on the day of judgment.

- They also show that he will keep/take bad people and punish them continually until the day when he will judge all people.
- And we^(incl) can also be certain that he will not only punish the wicked people now but also keep them until the day when he will judge everyone.

to hold the unrighteous for punishment on the day of judgment: The literal meaning of this part of the verse is “to keep the wicked, being punished, for the day of judgment.” This part of the verse probably means one of two things:

1. God is guarding wicked people carefully to prevent them from escaping so that he will be able to judge them on the Day of Judgement, when he will judge everyone. At the same time, he is already punishing them. The participle “being punished” is present tense which normally shows that the action is happening at the same time as the main verb (in this verse the main verb is “kept,” which the BSB translates as hold). For example:

how to keep the wicked under punishment for the Day of Judgement (GNT)

and to keep the unrighteous under punishment until the day of judgement (RSV) (NIV, GNT, RSV)

1. God will finally condemn and punish wicked people on the Day of Judgement. Until then, he will guard them to prevent them from escaping. The present participle can have a future sense, and the words “judge” and “punish” usually refer to the final judgement, so some scholars believe that it is future punishment which Peter has referred to here.

and how to reserve his punishment for the wicked until their day comes (JBP)

and hold the wicked for their punishment until the day of Judgement (JB) (BSB, JBP, JB)

It is recommended that you follow the first interpretation (1), which is in the Meaning Line of the Display.

2 Peter 2:10

Section 2:1–22: Peter warned believers against false teachers

In this section, Peter warned the people who read his letter against false teachers who behaved wickedly and who would try to encourage believers to behave in the same immoral way as they did. But God would certainly destroy these false teachers.

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2:10a

Such punishment is specially reserved for those who indulge the corrupt desires of the flesh and despise authority.

- Above all, he will severely punish those people who do shameful things which their bodies want to do and which defile them, and who reject God’s right to rule over them.
- God will punish all wicked people but he will punish very severely those who do the shameful things which they want to do and which make them morally impure and those who think they do not need to obey his commands.

God will punish all people who do wrong. In verses 4–9, Peter had been talking about such people in general, but now in verse 10, he returned to the false teachers whom, he said, God would punish especially severely.

He gave two reasons for this: their immoral behavior and the way they despised authority.

the flesh: The BSB translates the Greek word literally as flesh. This refers to the fact that people want to do what their bodies desire to do, even if this is something wrong. In this verse, Peter was referring to sinful sexual behavior which causes people to think and behave in an impure way.

authority: This probably refers to the right that God and Christ have to rule people. GNT: “and despise God’s authority.” But some scholars think it means the right that any person has to rule people. If these scholars are correct, Peter was talking about people who not only despised God’s right to rule people but also despised the right that humans, for example government and church leaders, have to rule other people.

Paragraph 2:10b–13a

Peter was saying that the false teachers did all kinds of wicked things. They did not show respect for anyone, not even those greater than themselves. They behaved like wild animals, doing only what their bodies desired to do. Because they were so evil, and because they enticed others to behave as they themselves did, God would destroy them.

2:10b

Bold and self-willed,

- ¶ These false teachers whom I am speaking about are not afraid to do what they want to do. They are proud.

Bold: This word can mean “courageous,” which is something good. But here it described people who dared to do all kinds of wrong things because they did not respect and fear God as people should respect and fear him, and because they did not care about other people.

self-willed: This word described people who were proud and stubborn. They did not listen to anyone else. Instead, they did exactly what they wanted to do.

2:10c

they are unafraid to slander glorious beings.

- They are not afraid to insult those beings up above who have honor.

unafraid to slander: Most versions interpret these words like BSB in a way that refers to only one action. This is the most likely interpretation. Here is another example:

are not afraid of offending the glorious ones (JB)

GNT follows the other interpretation and refers to two actions:

“they show no respect—instead they insult them.”

glorious beings: The literal meaning of the Greek is “glorious ones.” It is difficult to know to whom Peter was referring. The word may refer to:

1. angels or other heavenly beings, maybe the wicked angels that Peter mentioned in verse 4. The parallel verses 8–11 in Jude clearly refer to angels.
2. important people such as emperors, magistrates, or important church leaders. But this is less likely since the word usually refers to spiritual beings.

If possible, it is better to choose a neutral expression which could refer to any living beings, heavenly or human leaders. But if this is impossible, choose one of these interpretations and translate it that way. Then if you are using footnotes, explain the other interpretation in a note.

2 Peter 2:11

Section 2:1–22: Peter warned believers against false teachers

In this section, Peter warned the people who read his letter against false teachers who behaved wickedly and who would try to encourage believers to behave in the same immoral way as they did. But God would certainly destroy these false teachers.

Many of the verses in this section are similar to verses in Jude’s letter. Whoever wrote second, Peter or Jude, may have had a copy of the other one’s letter and used words and ideas out of that letter. Or perhaps someone else had written something with similar words and ideas in it, and Peter and Jude both used words and ideas from that writing. Why these two letters are so similar is not the most important thing. But if you have already translated Jude, it is important to have that translation open in front of you while you are studying and translating this section of 2 Peter. However be careful not to copy any verse exactly from Jude’s letter to your translation of 2 Peter, because there are differences between them which must remain in your translation.

Paragraph 2:10b–13a

Peter was saying that the false teachers did all kinds of wicked things. They did not show respect for anyone, not even those greater than themselves. They behaved like wild animals, doing only what their bodies desired to do. Because they were so evil, and

because they enticed others to behave as they themselves did, God would destroy them.

2:11a

Yet not even angels, though greater in strength and power,

- Even angels who are very much stronger than the false teachers,

greater in strength and power: These two expressions mean almost the same thing, so they are probably a pair of words that Peter used together in this sentence in order to emphasize how powerful the angels that he is talking about are. Then this expression means, “have much greater power.”

In the Greek it is not clear whom Peter was saying the angels were stronger than, but in many languages it will be necessary to state this. Many scholars think that Peter meant to say that the angels were stronger than the false teachers. Others think he meant that the angels were stronger than the celestial beings. If your language requires that you say whom the angels are stronger than, we recommend that you say that they are stronger than the false teachers. For example:

so much stronger and mightier than these false teachers (GNT)

2:11b

dare to bring such slanderous charges against them before the Lord.

- do not insult those beings who have honor when they accuse them in front of the Lord God.

dare to bring such slanderous charges against them: Peter said that the angels do not bring slanderous accusations against them. Here is another way to translate this:

do not pronounce a reviling judgement upon them. (GNT)

It is not clear to whom Peter was referring when he used the word them.

1. In some translations, them refers to the heavenly beings of verse 10c. If this is the correct interpretation, then the meaning is that the false teachers insult the heavenly beings, but the angels, who are even more powerful, do not. (BSB, NIV, NEB, JB)
2. In the GNT, them refers to the false teachers. If this is the correct interpretation, then Peter was contrasting the false teachers, who insult the heavenly beings, with the angels. Even when the angels are

telling God about the wrong things the false teachers have done, they do not use insulting language to do so.

It is recommended that you follow the first interpretation (1).

Lord: This is referring to God, not Christ, in this verse. See note on 2:9a.

2 Peter 2:12

Section 2:1–22: Peter warned believers against false teachers

In this section, Peter warned the people who read his letter against false teachers who behaved wickedly and who would try to encourage believers to behave in the same immoral way as they did. But God would certainly destroy these false teachers.

Many of the verses in this section are similar to verses in Jude’s letter. Whoever wrote second, Peter or Jude, may have had a copy of the other one’s letter and used words and ideas out of that letter. Or perhaps someone else had written something with similar words and ideas in it, and Peter and Jude both used words and ideas from that writing. Why these two letters are so similar is not the most important thing. But if you have already translated Jude, it is important to have that translation open in front of you while you are studying and translating this section of 2 Peter. However be careful not to copy any verse exactly from Jude’s letter to your translation of 2 Peter, because there are differences between them which must remain in your translation.

Paragraph 2:10b–13a

Peter was saying that the false teachers did all kinds of wicked things. They did not show respect for anyone, not even those greater than themselves. They behaved like wild animals, doing only what their bodies desired to do. Because they were so evil, and because they enticed others to behave as they themselves did, God would destroy them.

2:12

There are a couple of places in this verse where scholars understand the Greek in different ways. These Notes follow one widely accepted interpretation. Peter compared the false teachers to wild animals who behave according to their instinct. They act without thinking, according to what they want to do. God will destroy these false teachers in the same way that men catch and kill wild animals.

2:12a

These men are like irrational animals, creatures of instinct, born to be captured and destroyed. They blaspheme in matters they do not understand,

- But these false teachers behave like wild animals who have no power to think but do only what their bodies want to do. Such animals are born so that people can catch and kill them. Because they are like these animals, these teachers say bad things about matters they know nothing about.
- But these teachers act like senseless animals who act as their bodies want to and who are born so that people can trap and kill them. Because they are like these animals, these teachers insult things that they really know nothing about.

like irrational animals, creatures of instinct: This is probably a pair of words that Peter used together in this sentence in order to emphasize how much like animals these false teachers were. The false teachers did only what the desires of their bodies drove them to do, like animals who do not think about what they do.

blaspheme: In English this word means “to say bad things about holy things or people.” But the Greek word it translates here can also mean “to say bad things about ordinary people or things.” Some scholars think Peter was talking about saying bad things about “glorious beings” (see 2:10c). But others think he meant saying bad things about church or government leaders.

2:12b

and like such creatures, they too will be destroyed.

- God will destroy them in the same way as people kill animals.

like such creatures, they too will be destroyed:

Literally, “in their destruction they will be destroyed.” Scholars have interpreted this in many different ways, so it is difficult to be sure what Peter intended to say. Versions translate differently according to the interpretation they follow. For example:

1. Since the false teachers behave like wild animals, God will destroy them in the same way as people destroy wild animals. Peter used the same Greek word here for “destroy” as he used in 2:12a when talking about the animals being born “only to be caught and destroyed.” For example:

They will be destroyed like wild animals (GNT) (BSB, GNT, NIV, NEB, and RSV follow this interpretation.)

1. The wicked behavior of the false teachers will cause their own destruction. For example:

They will certainly destroy themselves by their own work of destruction (JB) (JB, JBP also follows this interpretation.)

It is recommended that you follow the first interpretation (1).

2 Peter 2:13**Section 2:1–22: Peter warned believers against false teachers**

In this section, Peter warned the people who read his letter against false teachers who behaved wickedly and who would try to encourage believers to behave in the same immoral way as they did. But God would certainly destroy these false teachers.

Many of the verses in this section are similar to verses in Jude’s letter. Whoever wrote second, Peter or Jude, may have had a copy of the other one’s letter and used words and ideas out of that letter. Or perhaps someone else had written something with similar words and ideas in it, and Peter and Jude both used words and ideas from that writing. Why these two letters are so similar is not the most important thing. But if you have already translated Jude, it is important to have that translation open in front of you while you are studying and translating this section of 2 Peter. However be careful not to copy any verse exactly from Jude’s letter to your translation of 2 Peter, because there are differences between them which must remain in your translation.

Paragraph 2:10b–13a

Peter was saying that the false teachers did all kinds of wicked things. They did not show respect for anyone, not even those greater than themselves. They behaved like wild animals, doing only what their bodies desired to do. Because they were so evil, and because they enticed others to behave as they themselves did, God would destroy them.

2:13a

The harm they will suffer is the wages of their wickedness.

- God will cause them to suffer greatly because they have caused other people to suffer.

It is better to include 13a in this paragraph which begins at verse 10b, rather than follow BSB which starts the new paragraph at the beginning of verse 12, because 13a continues to speak of how God will punish the false teachers.

The harm they will suffer is the wages of their wickedness: There is a problem in the Greek text here.

1. Some manuscripts have a verb (*adikoumenoi*), which BSB translates as The harm they will suffer. This is the text most English versions follow.
2. Other manuscripts have a different verb (*komioumenoi*) “received.” For example:

And shall receive the reward of unrighteousness (KJV)

It is recommended that you follow the first interpretation (1) like BSB and the majority of English versions.

Paragraph 2:13b–16

The false teachers’ main pleasure was to feast and to get as much of food, things to drink, and sex as they wanted. It is bad to behave this way at any time, but these people were so shameless they didn’t even try to hide what they were doing by waiting until night. Instead they were doing these things in the daytime, when everyone could see them behaving in such a way. So the false teachers brought shame on the Christians when they joined them for meals together.

Peter compared the false teachers to the prophet Balaam. Read the story of Balaam in Numbers 22–24. Balak, the king of the country of Moab, offered to reward Balaam if he would curse the people of Israel. Balaam was greedy to get the reward which Balak had offered him. That is why he tried three times to curse the people of Israel, even though he knew God didn’t want him to do it. But each time he tried to curse the people of Israel, he failed, because God caused him to bless them instead.

When Balaam was first going to Balak, God sent his angel to block Balaam’s way. Balaam could not see the angel, but the donkey he was riding could see him and refused to go on. Balaam then beat the donkey, and so God gave the donkey the ability to speak and it protested against the unfair way that Balaam had treated it.

2:13b

They consider it a pleasure to carouse in broad daylight.

- ¶ These false teachers enjoy feasting excessively, and they do this even in the daytime.
- ¶ These false teachers think it is fun to eat and drink too much not just at night but even during the day.

carouse: The Greek word which BSB translates carouse means “luxury.” It can have a good sense, “delight,” but here Peter used it to mean “self indul-

gence,” that is, eating and drinking too much at feasts without any self-control.

2:13c

They are blots and blemishes, reveling in their deception as they feast with you.

- While they eat with you^(plur), they continue to enjoy their deceitful ways and so they spoil your reputation and bring shame on you.

blots and blemishes: These two words are very similar in meaning. Both spoil the garment or face where they are. Peter used the words figuratively. He meant that the false teachers were like blots and blemishes because the disgraceful way that they behaved when they were eating together with the Christians spoiled the reputation of the whole group.

reveling in their deception: The Greek word which BSB translates as reveling is connected to “carouse” in 13b, and it means to enjoy oneself by eating, drinking and behaving immorally without any self-control.

deception: The word Peter used here (*apatais*) There is also a problem with the Greek manuscript at this point. Some manuscripts have the Greek word *agapais* instead of *apatais*. This word is usually translated as “love feasts” and refers to the meals the early Christians used to eat together. It is also the word Jude used in the parallel section in his letter (Jude 12). No major English version translates “love feasts” in the text, though some do mention it in a footnote.) literally means “deceits.” However in some contexts, the word can mean “pleasure that involves doing wrong.” Here is another way to translate this verse part:

They are blots and blemishes, reveling in their pleasures while they feast with you (NIV)

While the false teachers ate with the Christians, they enjoyed indulging themselves.

The Meaning Line in the Display follows BSB. If you want to follow NIV, see the translation given above.

2 Peter 2:14

Section 2:1–22: Peter warned believers against false teachers

In this section, Peter warned the people who read his letter against false teachers who behaved wickedly and who would try to encourage believers to behave in the same immoral way as they did. But God would certainly destroy these false teachers.

Many of the verses in this section are similar to verses in Jude’s letter. Whoever wrote second, Peter

or Jude, may have had a copy of the other one's letter and used words and ideas out of that letter. Or perhaps someone else had written something with similar words and ideas in it, and Peter and Jude both used words and ideas from that writing. Why these two letters are so similar is not the most important thing. But if you have already translated Jude, it is important to have that translation open in front of you while you are studying and translating this section of 2 Peter. However be careful not to copy any verse exactly from Jude's letter to your translation of 2 Peter, because there are differences between them which must remain in your translation.

Paragraph 2:13b–16

The false teachers' main pleasure was to feast and to get as much of food, things to drink, and sex as they wanted. It is bad to behave this way at any time, but these people were so shameless they didn't even try to hide what they were doing by waiting until night. Instead they were doing these things in the daytime, when everyone could see them behaving in such a way. So the false teachers brought shame on the Christians when they joined them for meals together.

Peter compared the false teachers to the prophet Balaam. Read the story of Balaam in Numbers 22–24. Balak, the king of the country of Moab, offered to reward Balaam if he would curse the people of Israel. Balaam was greedy to get the reward which Balak had offered him. That is why he tried three times to curse the people of Israel, even though he knew God didn't want him to do it. But each time he tried to curse the people of Israel, he failed, because God caused him to bless them instead.

When Balaam was first going to Balak, God sent his angel to block Balaam's way. Balaam could not see the angel, but the donkey he was riding could see him and refused to go on. Balaam then beat the donkey, and so God gave the donkey the ability to speak and it protested against the unfair way that Balaam had treated it.

2:14a

Their eyes are full of adultery;

- They are always looking for a woman who will have sex/sleep with them.
- They never think of anything except committing adultery.

Their eyes are full of adultery: The literal meaning of the Greek is “eyes full of an adulteress.” This may mean:

1. They are always looking for a woman who is willing to have sex with them, or

2. They cannot look at any woman without wanting to have sex with her.

It is recommended that you follow the first interpretation (1).

2:14b

their desire for sin is never satisfied;

- They never rest from doing bad things.

their desire for sin is never satisfied: They never get tired of sinning. Here is another way to translate this:

they never stop sinning (NIV)

2:14c

they seduce the unstable.

- They deceive people who do not strongly trust Christ, and they lead them to sin.
- They deceive people who do not understand well what they believe about Christ and persuade them to behave in the bad way they themselves do.

they seduce the unstable: Because of the wrong things they were teaching and the way they were behaving, these false teachers persuaded people who were not strong Christians to give up the true way Christ taught them to live and to follow them in the wrong way. Some other ways to translate “unstable people” are “people who are not sure about what they believe about Jesus,” or “people who quickly change their thinking,” or “people whose loyalty to Christ is weak.”

2:14d

They are accursed children

- Because of all the bad things they do, God has cursed these people.
- Because of all the bad things they do, God will punish these people.

accursed children: Literally the Greek says “children of a curse.” This is a way of saying they are people whom God has cursed. What Peter implied by these words is that these false teachers were extremely wicked, so wicked that God had cursed them. People usually think it is wrong to curse anyone. But this verse does not mean that God has done something wrong. It means that God has declared that these people will go to hell and he will punish them there because they have sinned against him. You must translate these words carefully. If in your language the word for cursing always means doing something evil, it would be better to say “God will punish them.”

2:14e**with hearts trained in greed.**

- They have taught themselves to be very greedy.
- They have become very greedy indeed.

hearts trained in greed: The literal meaning of the Greek is “having been trained in greed.” The verb “to train” usually refers to a person training himself for a race. Here these false teachers trained themselves to become more and more greedy.

greed: This means “desiring too strongly to have more and more of something.”

2 Peter 2:15**Section 2:1–22: Peter warned believers against false teachers**

In this section, Peter warned the people who read his letter against false teachers who behaved wickedly and who would try to encourage believers to behave in the same immoral way as they did. But God would certainly destroy these false teachers.

Many of the verses in this section are similar to verses in Jude’s letter. Whoever wrote second, Peter or Jude, may have had a copy of the other one’s letter and used words and ideas out of that letter. Or perhaps someone else had written something with similar words and ideas in it, and Peter and Jude both used words and ideas from that writing. Why these two letters are so similar is not the most important thing. But if you have already translated Jude, it is important to have that translation open in front of you while you are studying and translating this section of 2 Peter. However be careful not to copy any verse exactly from Jude’s letter to your translation of 2 Peter, because there are differences between them which must remain in your translation.

Paragraph 2:13b–16

The false teachers’ main pleasure was to feast and to get as much of food, things to drink, and sex as they wanted. It is bad to behave this way at any time, but these people were so shameless they didn’t even try to hide what they were doing by waiting until night. Instead they were doing these things in the daytime, when everyone could see them behaving in such a way. So the false teachers brought shame on the Christians when they joined them for meals together.

Peter compared the false teachers to the prophet Balaam. Read the story of Balaam in Numbers 22–24. Balak, the king of the country of Moab, offered to reward Balaam if he would curse the people of Israel. Balaam was greedy to get the reward which Balak had

offered him. That is why he tried three times to curse the people of Israel, even though he knew God didn’t want him to do it. But each time he tried to curse the people of Israel, he failed, because God caused him to bless them instead.

When Balaam was first going to Balak, God sent his angel to block Balaam’s way. Balaam could not see the angel, but the donkey he was riding could see him and refused to go on. Balaam then beat the donkey, and so God gave the donkey the ability to speak and it protested against the unfair way that Balaam had treated it.

2:15a**They have left the straight way**

- They have stopped doing what is right,

2:15b**and wandered off to follow the way of Balaam son of Beor,**

- and they have started to do the same kind of bad thing which Balaam, son of Beor, did long ago.

2:15c**who loved the wages of wickedness.**

- This Balaam wanted money so much that he was willing to do wrong in order to get it.

2:15

See the paragraph under the Paragraph heading for more about the story of Balaam.

loved the wages of wickedness: Balaam wanted so much to get the things that King Balak offered to pay him that he was willing to do wrong to get them.

2 Peter 2:16**Section 2:1–22: Peter warned believers against false teachers**

In this section, Peter warned the people who read his letter against false teachers who behaved wickedly and who would try to encourage believers to behave in the same immoral way as they did. But God would certainly destroy these false teachers.

Many of the verses in this section are similar to verses in Jude’s letter. Whoever wrote second, Peter or Jude, may have had a copy of the other one’s letter and used words and ideas out of that letter. Or perhaps someone else had written something with similar words and ideas in it, and Peter and Jude both used words and ideas from that writing. Why these two letters are so similar is not the most important thing. But if you have already translated Jude, it is important to have that translation open in front of you

while you are studying and translating this section of 2 Peter. However be careful not to copy any verse exactly from Jude's letter to your translation of 2 Peter, because there are differences between them which must remain in your translation.

Paragraph 2:13b–16

The false teachers' main pleasure was to feast and to get as much of food, things to drink, and sex as they wanted. It is bad to behave this way at any time, but these people were so shameless they didn't even try to hide what they were doing by waiting until night. Instead they were doing these things in the daytime, when everyone could see them behaving in such a way. So the false teachers brought shame on the Christians when they joined them for meals together.

Peter compared the false teachers to the prophet Balaam. Read the story of Balaam in Numbers 22–24. Balak, the king of the country of Moab, offered to reward Balaam if he would curse the people of Israel. Balaam was greedy to get the reward which Balak had offered him. That is why he tried three times to curse the people of Israel, even though he knew God didn't want him to do it. But each time he tried to curse the people of Israel, he failed, because God caused him to bless them instead.

When Balaam was first going to Balak, God sent his angel to block Balaam's way. Balaam could not see the angel, but the donkey he was riding could see him and refused to go on. Balaam then beat the donkey, and so God gave the donkey the ability to speak and it protested against the unfair way that Balaam had treated it.

2:16a

But he was rebuked for his transgression

- But God caused Balaam's donkey to scold him for the bad thing he was doing.

2:16b

by a donkey, otherwise without speech, that spoke with a man's voice

- Even though donkeys do not speak, that donkey spoke to Balaam like a human speaks while it was carrying Balaam to meet the king,

2:16

God caused the donkey Balaam was riding to speak to him in a human voice, and this stopped Balaam at that time from doing something which would have been foolish.

2:16c

and restrained the prophet's madness.

- and it stopped the prophet Balaam from doing a stupid thing at that moment.

prophet: Peter called Balaam a prophet because Balaam predicted things that would happen to Israel and to other nations (read Numbers 24).

2 Peter 2:17

Section 2:1–22: Peter warned believers against false teachers

In this section, Peter warned the people who read his letter against false teachers who behaved wickedly and who would try to encourage believers to behave in the same immoral way as they did. But God would certainly destroy these false teachers.

Many of the verses in this section are similar to verses in Jude's letter. Whoever wrote second, Peter or Jude, may have had a copy of the other one's letter and used words and ideas out of that letter. Or perhaps someone else had written something with similar words and ideas in it, and Peter and Jude both used words and ideas from that writing. Why these two letters are so similar is not the most important thing. But if you have already translated Jude, it is important to have that translation open in front of you while you are studying and translating this section of 2 Peter. However be careful not to copy any verse exactly from Jude's letter to your translation of 2 Peter, because there are differences between them which must remain in your translation.

Paragraph 2:17–22

Peter continued to describe the wicked way that the false teachers behaved. Because they were so wicked, God was reserving a place in hell for them.

Peter used many metaphors and other figures of speech in this paragraph. This makes his words very vivid. You may not be able to use the same figurative language in your translation, but try to find other ways of making your translation as vivid as the original.

2:17a

These men are springs without water

- ¶ These false teachers are as useless as springs of water which have dried up.

2:17b

and mists driven by a storm.

- They are as disappointing as mists/clouds which strong winds drive away, before the rain can fall. What they teach does not help people to live in the right way.

2:17

Peter compared the false teachers to two things: firstly, to springs of water which have dried up, and secondly, to mists or clouds which the wind drives away during a storm and so no rain falls. Both examples refer to events that disappoint people. In the same way the false teachers disappointed people, because their teachings were worthless. People expected to learn from a teacher how to live in the way God wanted them to, but instead these teachers taught them the wrong way.

2:17c

Blackest darkness is reserved for them.

- Therefore God is keeping for them a place which is completely dark where he will imprison them.

Blackest darkness: Because the false teachers did this, God had reserved a place in deep darkness for them. Use whichever words you have in your language to best explain how intense the darkness was.

2 Peter 2:18**Section 2:1–22: Peter warned believers against false teachers**

In this section, Peter warned the people who read his letter against false teachers who behaved wickedly and who would try to encourage believers to behave in the same immoral way as they did. But God would certainly destroy these false teachers.

Many of the verses in this section are similar to verses in Jude's letter. Whoever wrote second, Peter or Jude, may have had a copy of the other one's letter and used words and ideas out of that letter. Or perhaps someone else had written something with similar words and ideas in it, and Peter and Jude both used words and ideas from that writing. Why these two letters are so similar is not the most important thing. But if you have already translated Jude, it is important to have that translation open in front of you while you are studying and translating this section of 2 Peter. However be careful not to copy any verse exactly from Jude's letter to your translation of 2 Peter, because there are differences between them which must remain in your translation.

Paragraph 2:17–22

Peter continued to describe the wicked way that the false teachers behaved. Because they were so wicked, God was reserving a place in hell for them.

Peter used many metaphors and other figures of speech in this paragraph. This makes his words very vivid. You may not be able to use the same figurative

language in your translation, but try to find other ways of making your translation as vivid as the original.

2:18

When the false teachers were teaching people, they used words and phrases which sounded very impressive and important, but really didn't mean much. However, because what they said sounded impressive, it deceived people who had recently become Christians and encouraged them to live in an immoral way.

2:18a

With lofty but empty words,

- When they teach people, what they say sounds important, but it is worthless.

lofty but empty words: Peter used two words in Greek which contrast with each other. The teaching of the false teachers was impressive or lofty (literally "very big, excessive"), but at the same time, it was also empty, it had no value or sense.

2:18b

they appeal to the sensual passions of the flesh

- They tell people that they can do the shameful things their bodies want to do,

Because what the false teachers said sounded so impressive, it deceived people and they believed it and acted in the way the false teachers said they could.

they appeal to the sensual passions of the flesh:

This refers to behaving in a sexually immoral way, acting according to what their bodies told them and what they wanted to do. See the note on 2:2a. The false teachers enticed the new Christians away from the truth by teaching them that they were free to act immorally if they wanted to.

2:18c

and entice those who are just escaping from others who live in error.

- and they use that promise as a bait to lure people away from the true/right way to live. The people whom they lure away have only recently stopped behaving like those who do those evil things.

entice: The Greek word which BSB translates as entice here is the same word as Peter used in verse 14 (BSB "seduce"). It literally means "to lure/trap/catch with bait." Peter has used it in a figurative way in both verses; what the false teachers say and what they promise (verse 19) sounds so good that it attracts people away from the true teaching and way to live, in the same way that a person uses bait to attract an animal so he can catch it.

those who are just escaping from others who live in error: This probably refers to people who had recently become Christians. Peter was probably referring to the same people as in verse 14, where he described them as “the unstable.” They were new Christians who did not yet completely understand all they believed.

Here Peter described becoming a Christian as “escaping from others who live in error.” Peter did not mean that they had run away from the non-Christians, but that they no longer behaved in the same wrong way as those people did.

2 Peter 2:19

Section 2:1–22: Peter warned believers against false teachers

In this section, Peter warned the people who read his letter against false teachers who behaved wickedly and who would try to encourage believers to behave in the same immoral way as they did. But God would certainly destroy these false teachers.

Many of the verses in this section are similar to verses in Jude’s letter. Whoever wrote second, Peter or Jude, may have had a copy of the other one’s letter and used words and ideas out of that letter. Or perhaps someone else had written something with similar words and ideas in it, and Peter and Jude both used words and ideas from that writing. Why these two letters are so similar is not the most important thing. But if you have already translated Jude, it is important to have that translation open in front of you while you are studying and translating this section of 2 Peter. However be careful not to copy any verse exactly from Jude’s letter to your translation of 2 Peter, because there are differences between them which must remain in your translation.

Paragraph 2:17–22

Peter continued to describe the wicked way that the false teachers behaved. Because they were so wicked, God was reserving a place in hell for them.

Peter used many metaphors and other figures of speech in this paragraph. This makes his words very vivid. You may not be able to use the same figurative language in your translation, but try to find other ways of making your translation as vivid as the original.

2:19

The false teachers taught the people who had recently become Christians that they could live however they wanted to live because they were free. In other words, these teachers taught that God no longer required people to obey his laws. But in fact, the teachers were

slaves to their own wicked behavior, and they themselves were not free to do what was right.

2:19a

They promise them freedom,

- They tell the people: “If you follow our^(excl) teaching, we promise you that you will be free, so you can do exactly what you like to do.”
- They promise people that if they obey their teaching God will no longer require them to obey his laws but they will be able to behave just as they want to.

freedom: Peter did not specify what the false teachers promised freedom from. Most probably they were promising that those who followed them would be free from the need to obey any rules on how a Christian should behave. They were probably teaching that Christians could therefore behave just as they wanted to, even immorally. In languages where there is no word for freedom, you could translate this as: “You are no longer under the law,” or “God does not require you to obey his laws any more.”

2:19b

while they themselves are slaves to depravity.

- But the false teachers themselves are not free to do as they like. They are slaves of bad behavior which will ruin them,
- But the false teachers themselves have no power to stop doing the wicked things which will destroy them,

slaves to depravity: The Greek word that BSB translates depravity is the same word that Peter used in 1:4, where BSB translated it “corruption.” See note on 1:4b. The wicked way that they behaved controlled them and would ruin them.

2:19c

For a man is a slave to whatever has mastered him.

- I call them slaves because, as people say, if a person allows something to control him, it is as if he were a slave to that thing, he cannot stop doing it.

For: This word links 19c to 19b. You may need to make the link clearer by saying something like “I call them slaves because....”

a man is a slave to whatever has mastered him: This was probably a well-known proverb. Peter quoted it to explain why he had called the false teachers “slaves of depravity” in 19b. They had allowed their desire to do wicked and immoral things control them and so now they were like slaves to those wicked actions and could behave in no other way.

mastered: The Greek word here means “overcome by, defeated by.”

2 Peter 2:20

Section 2:1–22: Peter warned believers against false teachers

In this section, Peter warned the people who read his letter against false teachers who behaved wickedly and who would try to encourage believers to behave in the same immoral way as they did. But God would certainly destroy these false teachers.

Many of the verses in this section are similar to verses in Jude’s letter. Whoever wrote second, Peter or Jude, may have had a copy of the other one’s letter and used words and ideas out of that letter. Or perhaps someone else had written something with similar words and ideas in it, and Peter and Jude both used words and ideas from that writing. Why these two letters are so similar is not the most important thing. But if you have already translated Jude, it is important to have that translation open in front of you while you are studying and translating this section of 2 Peter. However be careful not to copy any verse exactly from Jude’s letter to your translation of 2 Peter, because there are differences between them which must remain in your translation.

Paragraph 2:17–22

Peter continued to describe the wicked way that the false teachers behaved. Because they were so wicked, God was reserving a place in hell for them.

Peter used many metaphors and other figures of speech in this paragraph. This makes his words very vivid. You may not be able to use the same figurative language in your translation, but try to find other ways of making your translation as vivid as the original.

2:20–22

It is not clear about whom Peter was speaking in these verses.

1. He may have been referring to the false teachers. This is the most natural way to understand the Greek. Some English versions use the pronoun “they” here. As the false teachers have been the main subject of the verses which precede this verse, it seems that these versions follow this interpretation. (BSB, NIV, RSV, CEV)
2. Some scholars say that Peter was referring to the people who had recently become Christians. Peter used the same verb (BSB “escaped”) in this verse as he had used in verse 18 when speaking of those who had recently become Christians.

3. Or perhaps he was stating generally that if any person who had become a Christian returned to pagan ways, the result for him would be worse than if he had remained a pagan and had never become a Christian in the first place. Some versions translate the subject as referring to people in general. For example:

anyone (JB)

men (JBP) (JB, JBP, GNT)

This whole chapter has described the false teachers, and they are the subject of verses 18 and 19, so it seems most likely that verse 20 also refers to these teachers, though Peter’s words are also true about anyone who has turned away from following Christ. The Notes follow this interpretation. According to this interpretation, “If” at the beginning of the verse is stating a fact (as in 2:4). It is not referring to something that may or may not have happened. (See the last paragraph of the note in the introduction to 2:4–10a).

2:20

In the Greek, and in BSB, NIV, and GNT, this verse is one sentence, but you will probably need to break it into two or more sentences.

In the Greek text the word *gar*, which some versions translate as “for,” shows how Peter linked this verse to the verses which preceded it. Other versions like BSB, NIV, GNT and CEV leave the relationship implicit.

2:20a

If indeed they have escaped the corruption of the world

- I say that about the false teachers because they had come out from the power of the bad things of this world which spoil the hearts of people.
- They had left those sinful ways that ruin a person’s character. These are the ways which the people of this world who do not obey God habitually follow.

corruption: Literally “defilement, pollution.” The Greek word that Peter used here is not the same as the one he used in 1:4b, but the underlying meaning is almost the same.

the world: This does not refer to the physical world which God created, but to the non-Christians among whom the people to whom Peter was writing lived. These people practiced many immoral customs which ruined people spiritually. When Peter wrote about the “corruption of the world” in this verse he was referring to such immoral customs. See also note on 1:4b.

2:20b**through the knowledge of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ,**

- This happened because they had come to know Jesus Christ who is our^(incl) Lord and Savior.

through the knowledge of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ:

Peter has already used the expression the knowledge of several times in this letter (see 1:2, 1:8 and the notes on those verses). It is by means of coming to know Christ that a person is able to escape from living in the wicked way the non-Christians live.

2:20c**only to be entangled and overcome by it again,**

- But now once more they have gotten involved in doing bad things and those bad things now control them,
- But now they have allowed the bad things to again catch them and control them,

entangled: When used literally the Greek word which BSB translates entangled means “entwined.” It is the word used when a woman plaits her hair. Here Peter used it figuratively and it means “to be involved in, mixed up with.” This part of the verse says that the false teachers have once more got involved in the wicked way of living from which they had escaped when they came to know Christ.

overcome by it again: This is the same Greek verb as Peter used in 19c, where BSB translates it “mastered.” Here again Peter was saying that the false teachers, despite having once become free from the wicked things which non-Christians do, once more were allowing those things to control them.

2:20d**their final condition is worse than it was at first.**

- so their last condition/state now that they have rejected Christ is worse than their condition at first before they became believers.

their final condition: This phrase refers to the time when Peter was writing, the time after the false teachers had turned away from the true Christian teaching which they once followed.

it was at first: This phrase refers to the time before they became Christians.

2 Peter 2:21**Section 2:1–22: Peter warned believers against false teachers**

In this section, Peter warned the people who read his letter against false teachers who behaved wickedly

and who would try to encourage believers to behave in the same immoral way as they did. But God would certainly destroy these false teachers.

Many of the verses in this section are similar to verses in Jude’s letter. Whoever wrote second, Peter or Jude, may have had a copy of the other one’s letter and used words and ideas out of that letter. Or perhaps someone else had written something with similar words and ideas in it, and Peter and Jude both used words and ideas from that writing. Why these two letters are so similar is not the most important thing. But if you have already translated Jude, it is important to have that translation open in front of you while you are studying and translating this section of 2 Peter. However be careful not to copy any verse exactly from Jude’s letter to your translation of 2 Peter, because there are differences between them which must remain in your translation.

Paragraph 2:17–22

Peter continued to describe the wicked way that the false teachers behaved. Because they were so wicked, God was reserving a place in hell for them.

Peter used many metaphors and other figures of speech in this paragraph. This makes his words very vivid. You may not be able to use the same figurative language in your translation, but try to find other ways of making your translation as vivid as the original.

2:21b**than to have known it**

- than to have done what they have done. They had learned the right way to behave,

2:21

This verse further explains why the final result is worse for them than if they had never been Christians at all. The Greek text shows this relationship by using the link word “for,” which is left implicit in BSB, NIV, GNT and CEV. The Display line shows one way to translate the link.

This verse is one long and complex sentence in Greek. You may need to divide it into shorter sentences. The Display shows one way to do this.

2:21a**It would have been better for them not to have known the way of righteousness**

- What I mean is, because God will punish those who abandon/desert/leave Christ more severely than he will punish those who never accepted him, it would have been better for those people never to have learned how to behave in a way that God considers right,

It would have been better: Peter wrote that it would have been better for these people never to have known Christ than to turn away after knowing him. The reason is that God punishes those who sin even though they know that they are sinning more severely than he punishes those who sin but who do not know that they are sinning. It may be necessary for you to state this explicitly in your translation or to explain the reason in a footnote to enable your readers to understand this verse clearly.

way of righteousness: This refers to the way a person should behave in order to do what is right, to behave in the way God wants them to.

2:21c

and then to turn away from the holy commandment passed on to them.

- but then they stopped obeying God's laws that people taught them.

holy commandment: The holy commandment refers to God's law which tells people how to behave.

2 Peter 2:22

Section 2:1–22: Peter warned believers against false teachers

In this section, Peter warned the people who read his letter against false teachers who behaved wickedly and who would try to encourage believers to behave in the same immoral way as they did. But God would certainly destroy these false teachers.

Many of the verses in this section are similar to verses in Jude's letter. Whoever wrote second, Peter or Jude, may have had a copy of the other one's letter and used words and ideas out of that letter. Or perhaps someone else had written something with similar words and ideas in it, and Peter and Jude both used words and ideas from that writing. Why these two letters are so similar is not the most important thing. But if you have already translated Jude, it is important to have that translation open in front of you while you are studying and translating this section of 2 Peter. However be careful not to copy any verse exactly from Jude's letter to your translation of 2 Peter, because there are differences between them which must remain in your translation.

Paragraph 2:17–22

Peter continued to describe the wicked way that the false teachers behaved. Because they were so wicked, God was reserving a place in hell for them.

Peter used many metaphors and other figures of speech in this paragraph. This makes his words very

vivid. You may not be able to use the same figurative language in your translation, but try to find other ways of making your translation as vivid as the original.

2:22a

Of them the proverbs are true:

- What they have done is exactly what these two proverbs say:
- The way they behave shows that what these proverbs say is true:

2:22b

“A dog returns to its vomit,”

- “A dog vomits, and then eats it/the thing it has vomited.”

2:22c

and, “A sow that is washed goes back to her wallowing in the mud.”

- and, “After a person washes a pig, it goes back again to roll in mud.”

2:22

Peter ended his criticism of the false teachers by saying that what they had done was the same sort of stupid behavior as that of the dog and the pig in two proverbs which would have been well-known to the readers of Peter's letter. It will be necessary for you to study the form of proverbs in your language, and then to translate these proverbs in the same style so that they sound like proverbs.

2 Peter 3:1

Section 3:1–18a: Peter taught about Christ's return

Although some people were mocking the Christian teaching that Christ would return, Peter insisted that Christ would indeed come back to judge people. He wrote that at that time, God would destroy this present world and there would be a new earth where only righteous people would live. So Peter urged his readers to live in a pure and holy manner, so that they would be ready when Christ returned.

Paragraph 3:1–2

Peter said that he was writing this letter to remind them of what the prophets and the Lord Jesus, speaking through his apostles, had said.

3:1a

Beloved, this is now my second letter to you.

- ¶ My dear friends, I have already written one letter to you^(plur) and now I am writing to you for the second time.

Beloved: You should try to find a term that you would use in your language to express affection for someone.

second letter: The first letter may have been the one we know as 1 Peter. But Peter probably wrote several letters while he was one of the church leaders, so we cannot be certain about this.

3:1b

Both of them are reminders to stir you to wholesome thinking

- In both letters I have been trying to encourage you^(plur) to think correctly by reminding you of some things which you have already learned.
- In both letters I have reminded you^(plur) of things you already know, so that when you remember what I have written, it will help you think correctly about these things.

reminders: Peter said here, as he had said in 1:12, that he wanted to remind the Christians to whom he was writing of what Christian teachers had taught them, so that they would not forget it.

to stir you to wholesome thinking: The Greek text says: “to rouse of-you...the pure mind.” There are two ways of understanding this part of the verse:

1. He wanted to stimulate them to think pure and correct thoughts, rather than allowing the false teachers to contaminate their thoughts.

(BSB, NIV, REB, GNT, CEV)

1. The expression “the pure mind” means that their minds were already pure/sincere. “Rouse” means that Peter was wanting to strengthen their pure minds by reminding them of what the prophets and the Lord had said.

(KJV, RSV, NCV, JBP)

The difference between the two interpretations is slight. It is recommended that you follow the first interpretation, as BSB has done.

2 Peter 3:2

Section 3:1–18a: Peter taught about Christ’s return

Although some people were mocking the Christian teaching that Christ would return, Peter insisted that Christ would indeed come back to judge people. He wrote that at that time, God would destroy this present world and there would be a new earth where only righteous people would live. So Peter urged his readers to live in a pure and holy manner, so that they would be ready when Christ returned.

Paragraph 3:1–2

Peter said that he was writing this letter to remind them of what the prophets and the Lord Jesus, speaking through his apostles, had said.

3:2a

by recalling what was foretold by the holy prophets

- I am doing this because I want you^(plur) to remember the words which God’s prophets said long ago.

holy prophets: The basic meaning of the word holy is “having been set aside, separate from other things,” usually “having been set aside for God.” Things that people set aside from other things so that God can use them must be fit for him to use. That is why the word also means “not spoiled by sin,” and “pure/righteous.” In this verse the word holy has its basic meaning and means that God had set the prophets aside for himself so that he could use them. When Peter used the word holy here, he was not referring to whether the Old Testament prophets were righteous or not. So when you translate holy here, you should choose an expression which means “set apart for God” or “belonging to God,” rather than a word to mean “good” or “righteous.”

3:2b

and commanded by our Lord and Savior through your apostles.

- I want you^(plur) to remember too the teaching of our^(incl) Lord Jesus Christ, our Saviour, which the apostles who came to you taught you.

commanded: Here commanded probably refers to everything that Christ taught, not just one thing which he taught.

your apostles: The NT uses the word “apostles” for different groups of people and so there are several different opinions among Bible scholars as to whom Peter meant here. Some think he meant the twelve apostles. Some include Paul. Some think he meant those of the twelve who brought the gospel to the people who were reading Peter’s letter. Others think “apostles” has the more general meaning of “missionaries.”

If in your language you translate the word “apostles” by a term which uses the verb “send,” you may need to be careful that the phrase you use here for “your apostles” does not give the wrong meaning of “the apostles you sent,” but rather “the apostles Christ sent to you.”

2 Peter 3:3

Section 3:1–18a: Peter taught about Christ's return

Although some people were mocking the Christian teaching that Christ would return, Peter insisted that Christ would indeed come back to judge people. He wrote that at that time, God would destroy this present world and there would be a new earth where only righteous people would live. So Peter urged his readers to live in a pure and holy manner, so that they would be ready when Christ returned.

Paragraph 3:3–7

In this paragraph and the next one (3:8–10), Peter wrote about the people who would mock Christians for believing that Christ would return and would say that he would not return. Peter said that although Christ had not yet returned, he most certainly would return one day and that at that time God would destroy the earth.

3:3

Most importantly, you must understand that in the last days scoffers will come, scoffing and following their own evil desires.

- ¶ Most importantly, you^(plur) should know that during the time that remains before Christ returns, there will be people who will mock you because you believe that Christ will come back again. They will habitually do the bad things which please them. They will ridicule what you believe,

Most importantly: The literal meaning of the Greek is “first of all.” Peter wanted to emphasize that what he would say next would be very important.

last days: This refers to the time between Jesus ascending to heaven and his return.

scoffers: This means “people who mock, laugh at, or ridicule something.” In this context, Peter was saying that they would mock what the Christians believed, especially that Christians expected that Christ would come back again. These people very possibly included the false teachers of chapter 2.

2 Peter 3:4

Section 3:1–18a: Peter taught about Christ's return

Although some people were mocking the Christian teaching that Christ would return, Peter insisted that Christ would indeed come back to judge people. He wrote that at that time, God would destroy this present world and there would be a new earth where only righteous people would live. So Peter urged his readers to live in a pure and holy manner, so that they would be ready when Christ returned.

Paragraph 3:3–7

In this paragraph and the next one (3:8–10), Peter wrote about the people who would mock Christians for believing that Christ would return and would say that he would not return. Peter said that although Christ had not yet returned, he most certainly would return one day and that at that time God would destroy the earth.

3:4

Peter said that the people who were scoffing would say that Christ still had not returned, even though he had promised to. They would say that, although he had said that there would be various signs and wonders immediately before he returned (see Mark 13:24–26), these had not happened. There had been no change, and the world was the same as it had always been since God created it. The scoffers would claim that this proved that Christ would not return at all.

3:4a

“Where is the promise of His coming?” they will ask.

- and they will say, “Didn’t he promise to return? So where is he?”
- and they will say, “He promised to come back, didn’t he? But he has not come, and he will not come.
- and they will say, “He promised to return, but he has not. He was lying when he said that.

Where is the promise of His coming?: This is a rhetorical question which means: “He promised to come back, but he has not come.” Many languages use rhetorical questions like this to emphasize something negative that someone is saying, but even if you can use a rhetorical question in this way, you may need to change the form of the question. GNT may be a helpful model: “He promised to come, didn’t he? Where is he?” If you translate it as a statement, and not as a question, you must use a vivid expression. Some suggestions are:

“He promised to return, but those were merely empty words!”

“When he promised to return, he was lying!”

The source of this promise is both in Old Testament prophecies (see 1:19) and in the words of Christ himself (see Matthew 24).

3:4b

“Ever since our fathers fell asleep,

- We^(excl) say that he will not come because those who were our leaders at first have all died,

3:4c

everything continues as it has from the beginning of creation.”

- but still nothing has changed. Things remain the same as they have been since God created the world.”
- but still nothing has changed. Things continue to happen in the same way as they have happened since God created the world.”

3:4b–c

This part of the verse tells the reason that the people who are scoffing will give when they say that Christ will not return. The Greek text shows the relationship by using the word *gar*, “for.” BSB and other versions leave the link implicit. In the Display line for 3:4b, there is an example of how to show the relationship between 3:4b and the previous sentence.

our fathers: Literally “the fathers.” In Greek, as in many other languages, the word “father” means not only a biological father, but can mean “an ancestor,” “respected leader who lived in the past,” “the originator of something,” and “a person older than the speaker.” Because Peter spoke here of “the fathers,” he was probably referring to a specific and respected group of people who lived before the scoffers and to whom they were referring. There are different opinions about which group Peter meant:

1. the first generation of Christians,
2. the generation that preceded the generation of which the scoffers were a part,
3. the patriarchs and prophets,
4. the ancestors of the human race.

Although elsewhere in the NT the word usually refers to the important leaders in the OT, in the present context Peter probably meant interpretation (1), the first generation of Christians.

Jesus himself seemed to have said that he would return in the lifetime of the first disciples (see Matthew 10:23; Mark 9:1; John 21:21–22); angels from God promised Jesus’ disciples that he would return (see Acts 1:11); and his disciples expected him to return while they were still alive. So when the first Christians began to die and Christ had still not returned, some people, like the people in this verse, started to doubt that he would come back at all.

fell asleep: This is a euphemism for “dying.” If you have a euphemism for “dying” in your language, you could use it here.

2 Peter 3:5**Section 3:1–18a: Peter taught about Christ’s return**

Although some people were mocking the Christian teaching that Christ would return, Peter insisted that Christ would indeed come back to judge people. He wrote that at that time, God would destroy this present world and there would be a new earth where only righteous people would live. So Peter urged his readers to live in a pure and holy manner, so that they would be ready when Christ returned.

Paragraph 3:3–7

In this paragraph and the next one (3:8–10), Peter wrote about the people who would mock Christians for believing that Christ would return and would say that he would not return. Peter said that although Christ had not yet returned, he most certainly would return one day and that at that time God would destroy the earth.

3:5–7

In verse 4, Peter said that the scoffers would claim that the usual pattern of events in the world had not changed in any way since the time when God created the world. In these verses, Peter said that this was not true. For example, God had interrupted that pattern when he caused a flood to punish people for sinning against him. And he would interrupt the pattern again in the future, but this time he would destroy the world by fire. The general sense of this passage is clear, but there are many differences of opinion about the meaning of some of the details in verses 5 and 6. The Display follows an opinion that many people accept.

3:5a**But they deliberately overlook the fact**

- But they are wrong when they say this because, they deliberately ignore the things they know:

Here, Peter began to say why what the scoffers would say would be wrong. The Greek text shows the link with the previous verse by using the word *gar*, “for.” Most English translations leave this relationship implicit. In the Display line for 3:5a, there is an example of how to translate this part of the verse in a way that clearly shows this relationship.

deliberately overlook: The literal meaning of the Greek is “it escapes notice.” It may not make sense in your language to say “deliberately overlook.” Peter was saying that these people were choosing to ignore things they knew.

3:5b**that long ago by God’s word**

- that long ago God gave an order,

by God's word: Beginning in the book of Genesis, the Bible says that when God created the world, he did so by speaking, giving an order (see Genesis 1:3, 1:6, 1:9, 1:11, 1:14, 1:20, 1:24, 1:26.) This phrase probably goes with both 5c and 5d—God created both the sky and the earth by his word, and you need to make sure your translation makes that clear.

GNT makes this clear by treating “heaven and earth” as a single unit:

God gave a command and the heavens and the earth were created. (GNT)

In JB, the phrase “by the Word of God” applies only to the earth:

There were heavens at the beginning and the earth was formed by the Word of God. (JB)

This is a possible meaning of the Greek but less likely.

3:5c the heavens existed

- and by doing that he made the sky.
- and by means of that order he caused the sky to exist.

the heavens existed: Notice that here, the word heavens refers to the sky, to what is above the earth. Peter was not talking here about the place where God is. Peter used the plural noun heavens, even though its meaning is singular. Many NT writers use this form of the word, but it does not mean that Peter was referring to more than one “heaven.” This is also acceptable in English, but you should only use a plural in your translation if it is natural to do so.

3:5d and the earth was formed out of water and by water,

- By that same order he caused the earth to appear out of the water, and it was water that he used to make the earth.
- In the same way, by giving an order he used water to make the earth and he caused the earth to appear out of the water.

earth was formed out of water: There are two ways that we can understand this:

1. Peter was referring to Genesis chapter 1 which tells how God gathered the waters together into seas and made the earth (or land) appear out of the water.

2. Some commentators believe, however, that these words mean that God used water as the material from which he formed the earth.

It is recommended that you follow the first interpretation (1).

earth was formed...by water: The Greek word *dia* can mean “by” or “through.” There are again different opinions about what this means. The two main views are:

1. Many think this means that God used water as the instrument or tool by which he made the earth. Most English versions follow this interpretation.
2. Other scholars think the meaning is similar to that of the previous phrase “formed out of water.” In Genesis it says that God put a “dome,” that is, the sky, in the midst of the water and then caused the water that was underneath the sky to come together into one place so that dry land appeared. So these scholars think that, when Peter said “the earth was formed by means of water,” he meant that God formed the earth by doing something to the water, that is, by dividing it and gathering it into one place, so that the land could appear.

It is recommended that you follow the first interpretation (1) as most English versions have done.

2 Peter 3:6

Section 3:1–18a: Peter taught about Christ's return

Although some people were mocking the Christian teaching that Christ would return, Peter insisted that Christ would indeed come back to judge people. He wrote that at that time, God would destroy this present world and there would be a new earth where only righteous people would live. So Peter urged his readers to live in a pure and holy manner, so that they would be ready when Christ returned.

Paragraph 3:3–7

In this paragraph and the next one (3:8–10), Peter wrote about the people who would mock Christians for believing that Christ would return and would say that he would not return. Peter said that although Christ had not yet returned, he most certainly would return one day and that at that time God would destroy the earth.

3:6

through which the world of that time perished in the flood.

- And he destroyed that world of long ago by water. He sent a big rain and it flooded the earth and drowned all living things.

through which: The literal meaning of the Greek is “by which.” In Greek the word “which” is plural, and there are different opinions concerning what it refers to:

1. Some people think it refers to the water in verse 5, and this is how most English versions translate it; see also GNT: “and it was by water also.” There is a problem because the word “which” is plural. This may be because Peter was thinking of the water from above and the water from the seas (see Genesis 7:11). Or he may be thinking of “water” as plural, because the word for “water” in the Hebrew language in which the OT was written is always plural.
2. Others believe it refers to the water and the word (of God) in verse 5. It was by his word and by water that God created the world, and he used them both to destroy the world. According to this interpretation, the same idea—the word of God—occurs in each of the three verses 5–7. These people think it is unlikely that Peter would use a plural pronoun to refer to a single substance (water), and that he would then also repeat the word “water” later in the same sentence. So for these reasons they prefer this second interpretation.

It is recommended that you follow the first interpretation (1).

the world of that time: Peter has already talked about the flood in 2:5. There he spoke about “the ancient world” and probably he meant the same thing here. This expression then refers to all living creatures on the earth, especially people.

But some scholars think it refers to the whole universe including the heavens and the earth. If it did mean the whole universe here, it would match Peter’s reference to the present heavens and earth in verse 7. This is one reason why some people accept this interpretation.

2 Peter 3:7

Section 3:1–18a: Peter taught about Christ’s return

Although some people were mocking the Christian teaching that Christ would return, Peter insisted that Christ would indeed come back to judge people. He wrote that at that time, God would destroy this present world and there would be a new earth where only righteous people would live. So Peter urged his readers to live in a pure and holy manner, so that they would be ready when Christ returned.

Paragraph 3:3–7

In this paragraph and the next one (3:8–10), Peter wrote about the people who would mock Christians for believing that Christ would return and would say that

he would not return. Peter said that although Christ had not yet returned, he most certainly would return one day and that at that time God would destroy the earth.

3:7

Just as God commanded the earth to be created, he has commanded that the present universe should continue until the day when he will judge the world and destroy wicked men. Then he will destroy the universe by fire.

3:7a

And by that same word, the present heavens and earth are reserved for fire,

- In the same way as he did when he created the sky and the earth, God has commanded that the sky and earth which exist today will remain, so that later he can burn them with fire.

And by that same word: This refers to the word of God, which Peter first mentioned in verse 5. It means that in the same way as God used a word of command to create the universe, he is now commanding the future destruction of that universe.

3:7b

being kept for the day of judgment and destruction of ungodly men.

- He is keeping them until the day when he will judge all people and destroy the people who do not respect him. Then he will burn the sky and the earth.

being kept for the day of judgment: The verb, which BSB translates as being kept, is the same verb as it translates with the verb “held” in 2:4c and “hold” in 2:9b. See the notes on these verses.

destruction: See note on 2:1e.

ungodly men: See note on 2:5a.

2 Peter 3:8

Section 3:1–18a: Peter taught about Christ’s return

Although some people were mocking the Christian teaching that Christ would return, Peter insisted that Christ would indeed come back to judge people. He wrote that at that time, God would destroy this present world and there would be a new earth where only righteous people would live. So Peter urged his readers to live in a pure and holy manner, so that they would be ready when Christ returned.

3:8–9

These verses contrast with verse 5. Peter said that there would be some things that the people who would scoff would deliberately ignore, but he ap-

pealed to the people to whom he sent his letter not to ignore or forget one important fact: God does not count time in the same way that we do. To him one thousand years is not a long time, and one day is not a short time; they are both the same.

Some people thought that Christ was late in fulfilling his promise to return. But Peter said that was not true but that the reason why he had not yet returned was that he was giving people time to repent, because he did not want to condemn and destroy anyone.

3:8a

Beloved, do not let this one thing escape your notice:

- ¶ But you, ^(plur) my dear friends, do not ignore this thing that I will now tell you:

Beloved: See the note on 3:1a.

do not let this one thing escape your notice: The Greek pronoun that the BSB translates literally as your is not translated in most English versions. However, since it shows the contrast with “they” in verse 5, you should make this contrast clear in your translation.

3:8b

With the Lord a day is like a thousand years, and a thousand years are like a day.

- One day and one thousand years are the same/equal to the Lord.
- The Lord does not see one day as a short time and one thousand years as a long time. No, he sees them as both the same.

With the Lord: “Lord” in this verse and in the next verse may refer to Christ or God, but Bible scholars do not agree on which. These Notes will take “Lord” as referring to Christ in these verses. You may choose either, but be careful to be consistent.

2 Peter 3:9

Section 3:1–18a: Peter taught about Christ’s return

Although some people were mocking the Christian teaching that Christ would return, Peter insisted that Christ would indeed come back to judge people. He wrote that at that time, God would destroy this present world and there would be a new earth where only righteous people would live. So Peter urged his readers to live in a pure and holy manner, so that they would be ready when Christ returned.

3:9a

The Lord is not slow in keeping His promise as some understand slowness,

- Some people think that the Lord is delaying fulfilling his promise to return. But he is not delaying in the way they think that he is delaying.

3:9b

but is patient with you,

- Rather, he is being patient with you. ^(plur)

patient with you: Peter once again addressed his readers directly with the pronoun “you.” Perhaps the false teachers were influencing some of the people to whom Peter wrote this letter, and so he appealed directly to the people who would read his letter, rather than saying “patient with people.”

3:9c

not wanting anyone to perish

- He is delaying fulfilling his promise because he does not want to destroy anyone for sinning against him.

perish: The Greek verb here belongs to the same group of words as the word translated “destruction” in 2:1e. See the note in that verse.

3:9d

but everyone to come to repentance.

- But he wants everyone to change their minds and stop doing wrong.

2 Peter 3:10

Section 3:1–18a: Peter taught about Christ’s return

Although some people were mocking the Christian teaching that Christ would return, Peter insisted that Christ would indeed come back to judge people. He wrote that at that time, God would destroy this present world and there would be a new earth where only righteous people would live. So Peter urged his readers to live in a pure and holy manner, so that they would be ready when Christ returned.

3:10

Christ will return when no one is expecting him. At that time the universe will burn up and in that way God will completely destroy it.

3:10a

But the Day of the Lord will come like a thief.

- But although Christ may seem to be delaying his return, he will certainly return. He will come at a time that nobody expects him, like a thief comes when nobody expects him.
- But Christ will return. On the day when he returns, he will surprise people like a thief surprises people when he comes.

the Day of the Lord: In the OT this expression meant the day when God would defeat his enemies and

punish them. But the people who wrote the NT used the expression to refer to the day when Christ would return to judge all people.

come like a thief: Christ will come suddenly, at a time when people do not expect him to come. It may be necessary to clearly state this in your translation, otherwise the people who read it might think that Peter was saying that Christ is like a thief. If many people who read your translation think that it is not good to compare Christ to a thief, even when someone explains the similarity to them, then you should omit the reference to a thief and just say what the verse means. You could say something like “he will come unexpectedly.” Peter put the verb “will come” at the beginning of the sentence in the Greek in order to emphasize that Christ will certainly come.

3:10b

The heavens will disappear with a roar,

- At that time there will be a roaring noise in the sky, and the sky will disappear.

with a roar: The Greek word that BSB translates roar means “a rushing or hissing sound,” for example, the sound that a bird makes when it flaps its wings, or the sound that water makes when it flows in a river. Here it describes the crackling and roaring sound of a big fire burning.

3:10c

the elements will be destroyed by fire,

- Everything in the sky, the sun, moon and stars will burn up completely,
- God will burn everything in the sky and destroy them.

the elements: Most commentators think this means the heavenly bodies, such as the sun, the moon, and the stars. But people in Peter’s time who spoke Greek also used this word to refer to the basic ingredients of the physical world such as earth, air, and water.

3:10d

and the earth and its works will be laid bare.

- On that day, he will reveal everything that people have done on earth in order to judge them.

the earth and its works: The majority of scholars understand this to refer to the contents of the earth, whether made by man or by God. Most English versions follow this interpretation. It is recommended that you do so too.

will be laid bare: There is a problem with the Greek text here. The English versions treat the problem in different ways:

1. heurethēsetai “will be found.” Some Greek manuscripts say this. The difficulty with this word is to decide what it means in this context. Some scholars say it means that people’s deeds will be laid bare. At the time that God will judge people, he will expose the things that they have done. Others think that this is a rhetorical question: “Will the earth and everything in it be found?” With the implied answer: “No, certainly not.” Then it means “the earth and everything in it will not be found,” that is, they will have vanished. (BSB, NIV, NRSV, NEB)
2. katakaēsetai “will be burned up.” Some Greek manuscripts say this. (RSV, JB)
3. Some translations have “will disappear,” “vanish” which is equivalent to translating the first interpretation above as a rhetorical question. (GNT, JBP)

Scholars are not certain what Peter wrote. It could be any of the three possibilities above. So it may be best to follow the choice of the major translation used in your area. If you are using footnotes, you should add a note mentioning what the other manuscripts say.

2 Peter 3:11

Section 3:1–18a: Peter taught about Christ’s return

Although some people were mocking the Christian teaching that Christ would return, Peter insisted that Christ would indeed come back to judge people. He wrote that at that time, God would destroy this present world and there would be a new earth where only righteous people would live. So Peter urged his readers to live in a pure and holy manner, so that they would be ready when Christ returned.

Paragraph 3:11–13

Peter told the people to whom he wrote this letter that they should live in a manner that would please God because God would destroy the present earth and everything that is in it and there would be a new earth where only good people would live.

3:11–12

In the Greek, verses 11 and 12 are one sentence, but you may need to use shorter sentences in your translation as the Display has done.

3:11a

Since everything will be destroyed in this way,

- ¶ It is certain that everything will finish/disappear like this,
- ¶ It is certain that God will destroy everything like this,

3:11b

what kind of people ought you to be?

- so you^(plur) should think about the way you should behave, if you want God to save you instead of judging you.

BSB, NIV, and GNT interpret this part of the verse as a question: “what kind of people ought you to be?” This is a rhetorical question. Peter was not asking for information. He was telling the people to whom he wrote to consider how they should behave now that they knew that God would judge the world in the way that Peter had described. Peter was advising them that it was necessary to live in a holy and godly manner if they did not want God to judge them and to condemn them.

Other translations do not have a question. For example:

think what sort of people you ought to be (NEB)

you should be living holy and saintly lives (JB)

3:11c

You ought to conduct yourselves in holiness and godliness

- You^(plur) should be upright and please God in everything you do.

holiness: Here this means “pure, upright, dedicated to God.”

godliness: See note on “godliness” in 1:3a; also the note in 2:9a.

2 Peter 3:12

Section 3:1–18a: Peter taught about Christ’s return

Although some people were mocking the Christian teaching that Christ would return, Peter insisted that Christ would indeed come back to judge people. He wrote that at that time, God would destroy this present world and there would be a new earth where only righteous people would live. So Peter urged his readers to live in a pure and holy manner, so that they would be ready when Christ returned.

Paragraph 3:11–13

Peter told the people to whom he wrote this letter that they should live in a manner that would please God because God would destroy the present earth and everything that is in it and there would be a new earth where only good people would live.

3:12a

as you anticipate and hasten the coming of the day of God,

- Behave like this while you^(plur) wait expectantly for the day when God has chosen that Christ will return,
- and do your best to make it come quickly.

anticipate: The literal meaning of the Greek is “waiting, expecting.”

hasten: The Greek word that BSB translates as hasten could mean:

1. “hastening.” Most versions follow this interpretation. For example:

Do your best to make it come soon (GNT)

Work to hasten it on (NEB) (BSB, GNT, NEB)

Christians can hasten the day when Christ will return by prayer and repentance. This is the most usual meaning of the verb.

1. Or it could mean “be eager, desire earnestly.” In this case it emphasizes the verb “look forward to,” and both verbs together mean “eagerly looking forward to.” There is only one grammatical object in the sentence (“the coming of the day of God”). This supports the interpretation that the second verb is emphasizing the first. For example:

while you wait and long for the Day of God (JB)

It is recommended that you follow the first interpretation (1).

the coming of the day of God: This refers to the same day as “the Day of the Lord” in verse 10. It is the day on which God has decided that Christ will return. You could translate it in this way:

as you look forward to Christ returning on the day that God has decided.

3:12b

when the heavens will be destroyed by fire

- On that day the sky will burn with fire,
- On that day God will destroy the sky with fire,

3:12c

and the elements will melt in the heat.

- the heat of that fire will melt even the heavenly bodies.

3:12b–c

The description of the end of the world in verse 12 is very similar to verse 10, so see notes on 3:10.

2 Peter 3:13

Section 3:1–18a: Peter taught about Christ's return

Although some people were mocking the Christian teaching that Christ would return, Peter insisted that Christ would indeed come back to judge people. He wrote that at that time, God would destroy this present world and there would be a new earth where only righteous people would live. So Peter urged his readers to live in a pure and holy manner, so that they would be ready when Christ returned.

Paragraph 3:11–13

Peter told the people to whom he wrote this letter that they should live in a manner that would please God because God would destroy the present earth and everything that is in it and there would be a new earth where only good people would live.

3:13

But in keeping with God's promise, we are looking forward to a new heaven and a new earth, where righteousness dwells.

- But God has promised that he will make a new sky and a new earth. All people on the new earth will do only what is right. It is these things that we^(incl) are waiting for.
- But we^(incl) are expecting God to make a new sky and a new earth, because he has promised to do that. There, all people will do only what is right.

In Isaiah 65:17, God says, “Behold, I will create new heavens and a new earth,” (see also Isaiah 66:22). It is very possible that Peter was thinking here about what Isaiah had recorded in those passages.

where righteousness dwells: The meaning is that in that place everything will be good, and people will do only what is right and just.

2 Peter 3:14

Section 3:1–18a: Peter taught about Christ's return

Although some people were mocking the Christian teaching that Christ would return, Peter insisted that Christ would indeed come back to judge people. He wrote that at that time, God would destroy this present world and there would be a new earth where only righteous people would live. So Peter urged his readers to live in a pure and holy manner, so that they would be ready when Christ returned.

Paragraph 3:14–16

In this paragraph and the following one, Peter told the people to whom he wrote this letter that while they waited for the day when Christ would return, they should try very hard in every way to behave in

a manner which pleases God and to carefully guard themselves against those people who would cause them to doubt what they believed.

3:14a

Therefore, beloved, as you anticipate these things,

- ¶ Therefore, my dear friends, because you^(plur) are waiting for all these things to happen,

beloved: See note on 3:1a.

these things: The BSB translates the Greek pronoun as these things because the form in Greek is plural. Most scholars think it refers to the new heavens and the new earth, but it could also refer to all the events that Peter, in the verses immediately preceding this one, had said would happen on the Day of the Lord. These events will include God's creation of new heavens and a new earth after he has destroyed the old ones.

3:14b

make every effort to be found at peace—spotless and blameless in His sight.

- try hard to do only what is right, so that God will consider you^(plur) pure, so that he will not say that you have behaved badly, and so that God will see that you^(plur) are at peace with him.
- try hard to do only what is right, so that God will consider you^(plur) pure, without fault, and at peace with him when Christ returns,

to be found at peace—spotless and blameless: The verb to be found applies to at peace and spotless and blameless. Peter was telling his readers that they were to do their best so that when Christ returned, God would find them pure, blameless, and at “peace” with him.

to be found...spotless: This means “that God may see that you are pure,” or “that you may be pure in God's sight.” Most scholars think that this refers to being in this pure condition when Christ returns. But some people think it means being pure now and always. Whatever it means, in order to be sure that God will consider a person pure when Christ returns, that person needs to try hard to remain spotless at all times.

spotless and blameless: These two words are very similar in meaning. People often used them to describe a perfect animal which was fit to sacrifice to God. When people used these words about an animal they were going to sacrifice, they were referring to the physical condition of the animal, but here Peter was referring to the spiritual condition of the people to whom he was writing. He wanted them to guard

themselves so that they would not do wrong in any way.

If it is difficult in your language to find two words with this meaning, you could use only one and strengthen it by using “very” or “completely.” For example:

completely pure

in His sight: The Greek word that BSB translates as in His sight could also mean “to him” or “by him.” Because the order of the words in Greek is ambiguous, it is not certain which other part of the sentence this phrase belongs to. Some scholars think that it goes with “at peace,” while others think that it goes with “to be found” or with “spotless and blameless.” So there are the following interpretations:

1. “at peace with him,” or, in other words, at peace with God. (NIV and NLT translate it in this way.)
2. “to be found by him,” or, in other words, he sees them in this condition. (NRSV and JB translate it in this way.)
3. “spotless and blameless to him,” or, in other words, in his sight. (BSB translates it in this way.)

According to the second and third interpretations, Peter did not say with whom the readers should be at peace. He was probably talking about peace with God, but he may have been talking about peace with their neighbors and fellow Christians, too.

Some versions seem to combine (1) and (3). For example:

to be pure and blameless in God’s sight and to be at peace with him. (GNT)

2 Peter 3:15

Section 3:1–18a: Peter taught about Christ’s return

Although some people were mocking the Christian teaching that Christ would return, Peter insisted that Christ would indeed come back to judge people. He wrote that at that time, God would destroy this present world and there would be a new earth where only righteous people would live. So Peter urged his readers to live in a pure and holy manner, so that they would be ready when Christ returned.

Paragraph 3:14–16

In this paragraph and the following one, Peter told the people to whom he wrote this letter that while they waited for the day when Christ would return, they should try very hard in every way to behave in a manner which pleases God and to carefully guard

themselves against those people who would cause them to doubt what they believed.

3:15a

Consider also that our Lord’s patience brings salvation,

- Recognise that the reason that our^(incl) Lord is patient, and is delaying his return is because he wants to give people time to repent so that he can save them instead of punishing/condemning them.

This verse expresses the same idea as in verse 9: The Lord was being patient and had delayed his return to give people the opportunity to repent so that he could save them instead of punishing them.

Lord: is ambiguous, and could refer to God or Christ. You should probably make the same decision here as you made for verses 9–10.

3:15b

just as our beloved brother Paul also wrote you with the wisdom God gave him.

- Our^(incl) fellow-believer Paul, whom we love, also wrote to you^(plur) the same things that I am now telling you. He wrote those things with the wisdom that God gave him.
- When our^(incl) brother Paul, whom we love, wrote to you^(plur) using the wisdom God had given him, he also told you these same things that I have told you.

Peter said that Paul wrote the same things about the Lord’s return in his letter to them. He called Paul “our beloved brother.” Some scholars think it means “our beloved fellow believer.” The NT often refers to fellow believers as “brothers.” If that is the correct interpretation, then “our” is inclusive. Other scholars think that Peter meant “our beloved fellow apostle.” If that is the correct interpretation, then “our” is exclusive.

2 Peter 3:16

Section 3:1–18a: Peter taught about Christ’s return

Although some people were mocking the Christian teaching that Christ would return, Peter insisted that Christ would indeed come back to judge people. He wrote that at that time, God would destroy this present world and there would be a new earth where only righteous people would live. So Peter urged his readers to live in a pure and holy manner, so that they would be ready when Christ returned.

Paragraph 3:14–16

In this paragraph and the following one, Peter told the people to whom he wrote this letter that while they waited for the day when Christ would return, they should try very hard in every way to behave in

a manner which pleases God and to carefully guard themselves against those people who would cause them to doubt what they believed.

3:16a

He writes this way in all his letters, speaking in them about such matters.

- In all his letters that he has written to believers, when he speaks about these things, he writes the same sort of thing that he wrote to you.^(plur)

such matters: This could refer to:

1. General teaching about the Lord's return, as in verses 9–15a.
2. Exhortation about how people should live in a pure manner because they remember that the Lord will return. In verses 14–15a, Peter exhorted the people to whom he was writing to live in this way.

If it is possible for you to use a general expression here like most English versions, you should do so.

3:16b

Some parts of his letters are hard to understand,

- But some of the things which he has written in his letters are difficult to understand.

3:16c

which ignorant and unstable people distort, as they do the rest of the Scriptures, to their own destruction.

- People who have not learned well the things Christians believe, and who are not sure what they believe, explain the meaning of these difficult things in the wrong way, just as they wrongly explain the meaning of other passages in the Book of God. By doing this they themselves cause God to destroy them.

3:16b–c

Peter said that “some parts” of Paul's letters were difficult to understand and so those who did not understand clearly what they believed changed the meaning of them, and also of other parts of Scripture. Peter was also saying that doing this would cause God to destroy them. Maybe Peter was thinking of the false teachers he wrote about in chapter two, and saying that they were among those who did this.

Peter referred to Paul's letters at the same time as he was referring to other Scripture. This shows that already the Christians recognized that God had authorized Paul to write letters to groups of Christians in order to teach them what God wanted them to know.

ignorant: This means “unlearned, uneducated.” In this context, the word is not referring to ordinary educa-

tion. It refers to people who have not learned what Christians should believe.

unstable: This means “not firm in their faith.” Peter also used this word in 2:14c. Read again the note on that verse.

distort: This means “twist, change, explain in a wrong way.” Peter meant that some people were saying that what Paul wrote meant something different from what it really meant.

the rest of the Scriptures: Peter was probably referring to the OT and also to some other Christian writings.

destruction: See note on 2:1e.

2 Peter 3:17

Section 3:1–18a: Peter taught about Christ's return

Although some people were mocking the Christian teaching that Christ would return, Peter insisted that Christ would indeed come back to judge people. He wrote that at that time, God would destroy this present world and there would be a new earth where only righteous people would live. So Peter urged his readers to live in a pure and holy manner, so that they would be ready when Christ returned.

3:17a

Therefore, beloved, since you already know these things,

- ¶ But you,^(plur) my dear friends, already know that these things will happen.

This verse starts with a pronoun which emphasizes that here Peter has stopped talking about the people who were using the Scriptures incorrectly and started talking directly again to the Christians to whom he was writing, urging them not to allow the words of evil men to deceive them. GNT translates this pronoun like this: “But you, my friends.” BSB does not translate the pronoun with any special emphasis.

beloved: See note on 3:1a.

already know these things: Here these things may refer to all that Peter had been saying about Christ's return. Or it may refer to what he had said immediately before this verse, in verse 16, where he wrote that people would destroy themselves by twisting Scripture.

3:17b

be on your guard

- Therefore, be careful

3:17c

so that you will not be carried away by the error of the lawless

- so that people who do not obey laws will not lead you^(plur) astray by telling you lies.

the lawless: See note on 2:7b.

3:17d

and fall from your secure standing.

- If you^(plur) follow them, you will stop believing the true things.
- If you^(plur) listen to them, you will begin to doubt what you once firmly believed.

secure standing: The literal meaning of the Greek is “stability.” This word is the opposite of “unstable” in the previous verse. If they listened to false teaching, they would doubt what they had believed, and they would no longer firmly trust in Christ. In some languages you can use an idiom like: “you will leave God’s road and get lost.”

2 Peter 3:18**Section 3:1–18a: Peter taught about Christ’s return**

Although some people were mocking the Christian teaching that Christ would return, Peter insisted that Christ would indeed come back to judge people. He wrote that at that time, God would destroy this present world and there would be a new earth where only righteous people would live. So Peter urged his readers to live in a pure and holy manner, so that they would be ready when Christ returned.

3:18a

But grow in the grace and knowledge of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ.

- Instead, continue to behave in a way which pleases our^(incl) Lord Jesus Christ, who is our Saviour, so that he may act more and more kindly towards you.^(plur) Continue also to know him better and better.

Peter ended his letter by appealing to his readers to grow in the way that they trusted Christ. This is similar to the way he began his letter (see paragraph 1:5–9).

grow in the grace...of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ: Scholars interpret these words in different ways:

1. “grace” means “God’s blessing and favor.” According to this interpretation, Peter was telling the people to whom he was writing to continue to trust in Christ and obey him, so that Christ would bless them more and more.

2. “grace of Christ” means “the good character/qualities of Christ.” According to this interpretation, Peter was telling the people to whom he was writing that they should try to develop in themselves more and more of the good character that Christ showed. This fits in with what Peter said at the beginning of his letter (see 1:5–9).

It is recommended that you follow the first interpretation (1), if you need to be specific in your translation. If, however, you follow the second interpretation, you could say something like:

Try to live/behave more and more in the good way that Jesus Christ, who is our Lord and our Savior, lived.

The tense of the Greek verb (present imperative) shows that the action is continuous. Here is another way to translate this:

Continue to grow (GNT)

grow in the...knowledge of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ: This could mean:

1. continually get to know our Lord better and better,
2. continually increase what you know about our Lord. Learn more and more about how he lived and what he taught,
3. get more and more of the knowledge which our Lord gives.

It is recommended that you follow the first interpretation.

3:18b

To Him be the glory both now and to the day of eternity. Amen.

- ¶ Let people/us^(incl) honor him now and forever. Amen.